CORHC-0003 — Clark Welch & Ray Albin Oral History — October 01, 2008

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:00
I'm leaving this fairly open-ended so you can just I know you guys will just run with it.

Ray Albin
00:07
And Clark will go first, I mean on the rank thing and all that.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:10
That's however you guys want to do it.

Clark Welch
00:12
It just occurred to me.

Ray Albin
00:15
Right. Okay.

Clark Welch
00:16
Can you give me a minute to put my hearing aids on? I'm sorry.

Andrew Woods
00:18
No, that's fine. Go ahead.

Clark Welch
00:23
Okay. Well don't start him yet. Or ask Ray something.

00:27
I've heard I've heard all his bullshit. Go ahead and get do it. Oh I did I'll ask no Yeah.

Andrew Woods
00:36
Guy, if you have something sensitive to say, you want to turn off the thing? We do. Okay, there is Yeah, right. Right, right. Yeah, our our last question on the list here.

Ray Albin
00:50

How would we indicate that then, Rich? I mean if we if we did say, just take a real good pause and then say

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
00:58
And he'll shut it off. And then Andrew will write the right. Yeah, it's it's good to p pause before you do that though so that we can We can shut shut off the tape and then edit the tape easily. So we if we don't I mean please you'll transcribe something. Yes.

Andrew Woods
01:17
In fact, I've got the transcript from our St. Louis for you. Okay. So I've got the time.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:24
Please feel free to you know speak freely. And if there's some something that you just don't want on, just let us know and we'll be very respectful of that and then we can talk about later, you know, the rules that you'd like us to follow with that information. It can always be cut out later too.

Andrew Woods
01:37
Right.

Clark Welch
01:40
Okay.

Andrew Woods
01:40
Right.

Clark Welch
01:42
Can't do that in life.

Andrew Woods
01:47
We'll find out if Joe Biden and Taylor.

Ray Albin
01:49
Oh my gosh. No, is it tonight or tomorrow? Tomorrow?

Andrew Woods
01:52

Tomorrow. Yeah, they didn't want to run up against the Cubs today.

Ray Albin
01:58
Can you imagine that? Can you imagine though the pressure that woman is under? I mean Biden's done this for a living. Yeah.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:09
Everybody ready

Ray Albin
02:10
Ready, ready?

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:13
I'm Carrie Tarasuk, the assistant curator of collections, here with Andrew Woods, research research historian at the first Division Museum at Cantini. On Wednesday, October 1st, 2008. We are here with Ray Albin and Clark Welch, both 1st Division veterans who fought at the Battle of Antan.

02:32
The purpose of this oral history is to allow us to ask follow-up questions. Carrie Tarasuk wrote her master's essay on the Battle of Ontan, and after researching her source her sources, a bibliography which will be attached. There were still some points unclear.

02:49
I'd like to clarify those today. This interview will also be a follow-up to the oral history done with Clark and Ray by Andrew and and carry at the first division reunion in St. Louis in 2007. To get started, Clark, can you please state your rank at the time of the battle, October 17th?

Clark Welch
03:09
I was a lieutenant.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
03:11
And Ray, will you also please state your rank at the time of the message?

Ray Albin
03:14
I'm a sergeant at that time.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
03:22

Operation Shenandoah 1 and 2, what exactly were their purposes? Can you give us some more information on One and two, please.

Clark Welch
03:32
Shenandoah one and two were two operations in the summer and fall of nineteen sixty-seven. They were conducted by the first Inverty Division. with the mission of to search and destroy the two seventy first regiment. The second of the 28th participated in that from 8 October until about 16, uh 17 October when they were taken out of the field. So Shenandoah 1, the second of the 28th did not participate directly in, but Shenandoah 2 they did.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:14
How do you think Terry Allen Jr. felt about the plan for October 17th? He followed orders, but do you think that he he had a problem with the plan itself?

Clark Welch
04:27
I don't think he did have a problem with it. I think that uh he was following orders and he expected it to be spectacularly successful.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
04:41
Clark, what was going through your mind right after your meeting with Terry Allen the night before?

Clark Welch
04:47
I had two meetings with Terry Allen on the 16th. The first one was in the tent when he gave the briefing to uh the leaders of the battalion as to what was going to happen the next. I think my conversation with him was very short when he put on the board what the plan was for the next day.

05:09
I believe I said something like, what? Jesus Christ, or something like that. Uh I've heard other people say I said more than that, but I remember it just saying, whoa, what?

05:20
And then I asked to s visit him in his tent and he said said sure. So after the briefing, he and I, and my radio operator, because I couldn't see very well in the dark, I'd just be in the lit-up tent, went to his tent and sat and talked for one minute or two minutes And that was where I said, sir, uh, I don't think I would have said, I don't think we should be doing this, but sir, we know where they are. We are going to find them right here.

05:49
I hope we're gonna blow the hell out of them all night. And uh his only response to that to me was uh that's what we're gonna do. It'll be a great day for the Black Lions.

06:01
gonna sneak up on them, it'll be a great day for the black lions. Those are my conversations with him. I don't know what he was thinking, of course, but that's what he said to me.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
06:13
What do you think of Newman's and Coleman's and Hayes' role in the battle?

Clark Welch
06:21
None. They arrived after the battle was over. Uh I saw General Newman Colonel Newman the night before before the night of the sixteenth, when I was briefing the senior officers on what had happened.

06:37
I don't remember Colonel Newman saying anything then. Uh General Coleman is where I don't remember. He did talk to me and he gave me a silver star for that day or before, I'm not sure.

06:51
Colonel Newman? Arrived after the battle was over. Now I can't say that for sure.

06:57
I can say I did not see Colonel Newman on the day of the battle. I did not see Colonel Newton. General Coleman on the day of the battle.

07:04
I saw no helicopters nearby on the day of the battle.

Andrew Woods
07:09
And we should clarify that uh Colonel Newman's the 1st Brigade Commander. Correct.

Clark Welch
07:16
General Coleman or is a Colonel Assistant Division Commander. And General Hay was gone. He was in Saigon. So General Coleman was the assistant division commander, but acting as the division commander because General Hay was missing. Gone.

Andrew Woods
07:32
At what time then? On the 16th or or on the 17th as well?

Clark Welch
07:35
Both days. That wouldn't be unusual. I I never saw General Hay. I saw him two, three times during the six months I was there.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
07:48
Now it was a bit unclear in some of my research, but were there any air attacks before the battle that morning?

Clark Welch
08:00
I am told there were. I have seen it in the logs that there were, but I can tell you I neither heard nor saw anything from the air on the 17th. I did not see or hear any helicopters.

08:17
I did not see or hear any Air Force bombs. Now the Air Force bombs could have been dropped, but they were certainly too far away to either affect me or did not affect the enemy at all in any way. on the 17th.

Ray Albin
08:34
And some of us, you know, listen, you know, you listen at night for things and it I heard, you know, we anticipated maybe there'd be airstrikes in the morning. beforehand and we never saw that. And like Clark said, perhaps there were airstrikes, but too far away to be effective for where Delta and Alpha companies were headed. So I never saw or heard any either.

Clark Welch
09:02
General Triet, who Colonel Triet, who I met later on. twice in Vietnam. He did not see or hear any B-52s or that's the word B-52s is their word from hell from the sky.

09:18
He didn't see or hear them. It was the reason he left at twelve o'clock, he told me, because the B-52s would come. But they certainly didn't come.

09:27
before I can't say that I did not see them, I did not hear them. And on the 17th, as on the 16th, our enemy was uh three meters away. That's from me to you to uh 100 meters away.

09:42
Anything more than 100 meters away, nothing. So if bombs were dropped, they were drop popped a mile away. No no no influence on the battle at all.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

09:58
Can you and I I would like you if you could use the um the board to to help and and illustrate but can you please describe the formations of the men on the ground, the enemy included. A Company of course went first and and D next. But if you can help us to understand the perimeter and how everything was sketched out, that would be wonderful.

Clark Welch
10:21
Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
10:25
And you may want uh it's up to you, you may want to use red and blue to determine the energy.

Clark Welch
10:30
The uh the things that were there. Uh Kam Si River, going that way, and the uh Wangtan River. Going that way.

10:49
Uh our NDP was right about there And the NDP was located so most of it was out in the open so the helicopters some of it was out in the open so the helicopters could land there, and the mortars could fire from there. Ray Albany was the mortar platoon. So within the NDP, Alpha Company, Delta Company, and Bravo Company, and then the headquarters in the middle and would have been my mortars there, somebody else's mortars there, somebody else's mortars there.

11:27
Part of it was in the woods. So the woods came along like that And then made that thing called the draw. And then went down like that.

11:36
So that's woods, jungle. All of this is heavy jungle. I will only try to tell you what I know to be true.

11:51
When it came time for us to leave, Alpha was to lead. So I was, our section of the perimeter was something like that. So I stood there and watched Alpha leave.

12:06
I wasn't leading. I stood there and watched Alpha lead. And they were in single file, first position.

12:12
Plato, second platoon, third platoon. So uh I know that because I've watched them leave. And

they headed, I say straight south.

12:22
Uh normally I was very good at navigation. I'd know exactly what I was doing and how far I was going. My job that way did was to follow Alpha Company.

12:30
So although I kept track of it casually, my job was to follow Alpha Company. Company, but generally we went straight south. Of course he came out there.

12:40
He was in single file. So later on, so I got room for Delta Company, the enemy's down here. Uh he had first platoon, second platoon, uh just give myself more room.

12:55
First platoon, second platoon, third room, in single file. I think he had a total of 60 people. So it's something less than 20, something less than 20.

13:07
One of them was about 10 men because half of this platoon was left back here I'm not sure which platoon was short. I just watched them all come by. And I think he and his little headquarters are right about there.

13:21
Now behind them, I had my company. I was in the opposite order, 3rd Platoon, 2nd Platoon, 1st Platoon. My first platoon's job was to stay tucked up behind Alpha Company.

13:39
These are companies Alpha Delta That just shows Alpha first That was my third platoon, and the job was to just, the army would call them connecting files. But his job was just to follow Alpha Company. And his first man was probably six feet behind two meters behind the trail guy in Delta.

14:06
And then I had the second platoon like that in two files. Now tell you why. And then I had the third platoon in two files.

14:17
And that's because right in here was the battalion TAC. That was a about ten men from the battalion headquarters. The battalion commander, Captain S2, two sergeant majors uh photographer, radio telephone operators.

14:39
But my I had two I had two jobs that day. One was to follow Alpha Company and the other was to protect these guys, the ten people. So that's what we look like.

14:52
Now every hundred yards or some distance The SOP was that you would stop and send out clover leaves. I don't know what Alpha did. didn't see him.

15:07
What we did, and I didn't expect to find anything because it had already gone through is really just to give, I don't want to say give the guys something to do, but In case there's some enemy meet snuck in on us. So every hundred yards or whatever it was, whenever Alpha Company stopped, and my first sergeant had a radio that was tuned to Alpha Company. So I didn't transmit on that, but I certainly heard everything that Alpha Company said.

15:34
So when Alpha Company stopped and said they were going to send out a clover leaf, I of course would stop and then I'd send out uh Couple men go out and find out if there was anything out there. So I did that. I don't know what Alfred did.

15:56
They should have done the same thing But that's what we did. We moved very slowly. We moved about 800 meters in two hours.

Ray Albin
16:03
And all that's being observed as we later found out by the Pabin.

Clark Welch
16:08
Yeah. That's where we were. And now I just shouldn't be in black here.

16:12
That's that's Ray Alban and his mortars. That's Alpha's mortars. That's Bravo's orders.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
16:18
You said that

Ray Albin
16:20
Right, right, yes.

Clark Welch
16:22
Now he didn't have a full platoon with him because what I knew is that when we out, when we went out, three or four or five or six or seven or eight of his platoon would come along with us because they wanted to get in it, to get something going. I don't think Ray came out that day, but I wouldn't have been surprised if he came out on the 16th when we went down there. So we

would have had three or four guys from a mortar plato, but the rest of mortar platoon and some other guys would have stayed back also, two or three people.

16:54
But I ended up with about seventy-five He had about 60. And that's the way we move. 400 meters per hour.

17:04
Very slowly. Thick, heavy jungle. It would have been called triple canopy, meaning There's bushes uh six or eight feet high.

17:14
Uh you didn't have to hack your way through them, sometimes machete. Usually you could just use your rifle, push the stuff out of the way. the way.

17:21
And then there were trees uh 20 feet high, and then there were the big tall jungle trees 100 feet high so that all kind of rained in there continually because water was was dripping down. He's very slow going. And I had talked to the Alpha Company commander the day before, night before.

17:42
There's a trail. One trail goes there. There's another trail that goes across like this.

17:54
And uh when I had made That big contact the day before was right there. And my had made contacts before when he landed on the first NDP, he was down there. So in my mind, the enemy, the enemy was there.

18:08
Enemy was there. I knew where they were. So I had told Alpha Company, you're gonna find them right there on that trail.

18:16
Be careful. And when I came back to Delta, company. Uh the recon uh the scout the uh mortar platoon leader was there you probably wouldn't have been there when I called my leaders together.

18:28
I said on my map tomorrow right there is where we're gonna find them. So bring plenty of ammunition. Then the enemy was doing.

18:42
He had been here for uh three or four or five days. This is based on my conversation with Colonel Triet. I believe Colonel Triet doesn't know reason for him to make up a story.

18:53
He had come in, crossed Highway 13, and come in here. He was out of food. He was tired.

19:00
He'd been chased by the Americans on the other side of 13. And he had come here to rest, to get rice. We had found all his rice because we are here and the rice came in from Cambodia.

19:15
Had no rice. He hadn't had any rice for two weeks. As he told me his men were picking leaves off the tree and picking grass off the ground and eating it.

19:26
And uh when they found a place where the rice had been, his men would go through and pick up the rice one grain at a time, and they didn't eat it. They picked up one grain of rice. And they brought them together.

19:37
They couldn't build a fire because they were afraid of us seeing the fire. So they just soaked the rice in water and then eat it. As he said, when you do that, you get sick.

19:47
When you get sick, you die, and you don't ever go home. So he was doing something that normally a regiment wouldn't do. Normally a regiment would be big and be walking through the you know one up and two back.

20:01
In this case, he had come and he had uh a battalion there and a battalion there. in a battalion. Uh there.

20:20
He was moving this way. He was supposed to join up with the ninth Influent Division over here by uh the mountain Nui Bauden. Uh his regimental headquarters was here He had two, he had his recon company out here.

20:42
They're the people that I'd found the day before. His recon three platoons were out there because there are open areas out there and he was afraid the Americans were going to land in the open areas. So he's there.

20:57
And he's resting, hiding. waiting for rice. And uh we got 142 people doing this.

21:06
I think right now, if we'd uh Put the numbers on there. We had a hundred and I say a hundred and forty-two. Other people say more than that, but we had 142 people.

21:23
Here. We had about uh three hundred people here.

Ray Albin
21:33
Later. Right.

Clark Welch
21:34
I mean uh now I think.

Ray Albin
21:36
Oh. Uh when su when Charlie Casey landed?

Clark Welch
21:40
Uh three hundred, four hundred wrong two hundred. Oh. We had about two hundred people there.

21:48
The enemy head, this is what Colonel Triadhood told me, and it is less than what the intelligence Report said. The intelligence report, which was put out on the 15th, but we never got, said that the 270, this is the 271st Regiment What we called it. Colonel Triet says that's the secret name they had to fool the Americans.

22:14
What they really were was 1st Regiment of 9th Infantry Division. So down here in red he had 1,200 people. And the intel report said uh 1,500.

22:29
I think he had 1,200 people. Scattered around here because this was a base camp run by Captain Locke. who I met over there.

22:37
Incidentally, Captain Lom's house is right there. Where Captain Lom lived. And his people were in ones and twos scattered around here because his job was to run this base camp.

22:58
Bring rice in from Cambodia. Kind of keep this place tidied up. So when units like the 271st came through, you could probably had a little hospital there.

23:12
at a clothing place, rice storage, a mechanical room to fix weapons. I saw all of those when I was back there. They're not there now, they're just depressing.

23:23
in the ground where they cave caved in. And this is the 8th, 83rd, they had about 200 people. And the The intelligence report said they had about 300 people.

23:37
So I think those are accurate numbers. That's how things were. This is probably at uh nine o'clock morning.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
23:50
Can you show us um just the contact, the point of contact?

Clark Welch
23:55
Oh okay. That that good th thing to do right here. The red guys didn't move.

24:03
Now what they did do, people talk about snipers being tied in the tree. That's not true. There were people watching us tied in the trees.

24:12
And he had wires strung through the trees back to the headquarters. This guy, I don't know if there's a person there, but he was up here. somewhere.

24:21
He's in the tree. Sometimes they're tied in the tree in case they fall asleep. They won't fall down.

24:27
Sometimes they just wrap some vines around around them. Sometimes they just get up there like a monkey and hang on. But their job is to call back by radio by telephone, not radio because we could hear it radio.

24:37
Telephone line strung in the trees. I'm sure there's one there. There's one there.

24:41
They saw us. They knew exactly where we were. None of them moved.

24:46
And we just kept coming south. When I talked to Colonel Triet, and we're standing right there on a depression in the ground. But caved in.

24:57
He said he prayed to his God that we would turn aside, but we kept coming. And incredibly Incredibly, Alpha Company came down to about here. So that's Alpha Company now.

25:16
And uh So this is what we look at at about it's nine forty five I guess. Now we're uh five meters to my right are bunkers. Now these had been built, and talking to Colonel Triet later, been built in the ground.

25:47
This is the long UN secret zone. They the Americans know that that's where the head of the Army, the North Vietnamese, or what they call themselves, People Army Vietnam, their headquarters was up here in Campo. Cambodia.

26:04
But where they did all their work was in the Long New Yem secret zone. We knew the enemy was there. That's a 271st look like that.

26:14
I can give you a better drawing of That's about 10 o'clock, a little bit before 10. We're still headed south.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
26:22
And the battle began at 10 o'clock, correct?

Clark Welch
26:24
Now let me put that on the next uh board. I've looked at the logs. They don't agree.

26:35
But the red hasn't moved, so I'll put them right on here again. He has one battalion there. One battalion there.

26:44
One battalion over here. And then of course the Captain Lam's people are all over the place. Not snipers in trees, just guy outside the crees keeping track of where we were.

27:07
That's twelve hundred people plus two hundred of them. Now when the battle started It was a few minutes before 10 o'clock when I heard on the tele radio, because I was listening to the radio, I heard the man say, I just saw six people running off to the West. We're going to chase after them and set up an ambush.

27:32
I wasn't with Alpha Company, but based on what I heard on the radio, and then the gunfire, and then when I ran up there later on what I saw on the ground. Now he has one platoon. What is trail platoons?

27:49
One platoon. The lead platoon has run off this way. His third platoon is there.

27:59
My platoon is there. He has three platoons. The first one has this is that trail that I showed you on the other map.

28:20
And his first platoon runs down the trail. I hear him on the radio. Chasing after six guys.

28:29
When I heard that, I told my guys that Alpha Company says they've seen six. That means at least sixty get down and spread out. We went a little bit further along to tighten it up.

28:44
So now we're up here a little bit. We kind of second platoon is now protect them. Uh that's my job is to protect the headquarters uh this platoon they should have been.

29:04
They are kinda out there like that now And this connecting file is still a file. Keep track of what's going on with alpha. At about 10 o'clock, 10.

29:19
56 1055 1005 depending on which brigade log you look at but about 10 o'clock just all hell broke loose and that was uh uh uh primarily this battalion tried to shoot at these guys I understand and they're in bunkers. Some were built for the Japanese, some were built for the French. They're all bunkers.

29:51
So uh tunnels underground 20 40 20 to 40 feet deep. So if you were getting a lot of good shots at Americans, you had the battalion that's about two, three You had everybody running up here and uh sticking their heads up and shooting at the Americans and then running running back in the bunker, getting more ammunition. So they all shot.

30:16
In the original fire, a few people shot at us. One guy shot and hit Captain Blackwell. The Captain Blackwell was the first one of my guys hit.

Andrew Woods
30:26
He's the S2?

Clark Welch
30:28
The S2. What the hell was he doing out there? Yeah, Captain Blackwell he has too.

30:33
He had told me a couple days before that he I would see him a lot because his real job was to be ready to take over D Company when I became a casualty And uh I say, well, good luck, you know, I'm not going to become a casualty screw ya. But Captain Blackwell, a couple of times before had walked with me. He never said anything.

30:57
He he was a good man. Very smart. He just walked along with me.

31:02
But he told me, so I'll know what to do. so I can take over when you become a captain. And we received a few shots.

31:09
And we received a few shots from guys that were in trees. Made people think there's snipers in the trees. Not really.

31:16
Just a guy's up in the tree with a radio and he's got a rifle and he sees Americans so he shoots them. So some of these guys were shooting at us. But most of the fire was coming from right there.

31:29
Five meters away, ten meters away. If you got much more than ten meters away, you couldn't see. Now, when a big fight starts, they had 57 millimeter recoilish rifles.

31:42
That's a that's a you don't blow up a tank. They were shooting those at us. They had 50 caliber machine guns, those captured from us, and also the ones they hit on the tripods because he had an anti-aircraft company.

31:55
with him. They had 50 calibers mounted on tripods. But so you just turn them down so it means 50 calibers are coming through about that high.

32:05
Tremendous amount of fire on Alpha Company, a little bit of fire on us. And uh my primary job was to keep them getting my guys down and And uh Carlin Allen said, Well what's what's happened to Alpha Company? get him on the radio.

32:30
And uh he either told me to go up there, I said I'll go up there. I'd already been up with uh this is uh Stroop. Ted.

32:43

Stroop, I just forgot his first name. Dave. Dave.

32:46
Lieutenant Stroop is up here. I ran up to the front And uh what I saw when I got there with Stroop, I said, what the hell? And Stroop said, they're gone.

33:00
And what I saw, what I saw, was a body laying there, body laying there, body laying there, body laying there, body laying there, body laying there. And I ran up there, I don't know how far I went. But I saw 10 to 20 bodies laying on the ground.

33:22
I picked up one or two of the guys that were wounded. When I say bodies, I couldn't tell. if they're alive or dead.

33:28
They're just soaking wet and they're laying on the ground. I saw those guys laying on the ground. I didn't see see anything else.

33:40
I don't know. I mean I personally do not know what Alpha Company did. I do know they weren't there.

33:48
Now from their own reports later on that they they ran back here. And back here is that draw that we showed on the other thing. The draw is kind of kind of a dry creek bed and uh the woods comes down like that.

34:11
It's all heavy woods. Yeah. I do know that I I could see, I could talk to no one from Alpha Company.

34:23
There's a tremendous amount of fire coming. Coming in from the right. None hit me then.

34:28
Yes, one hit me in the leg. Lieutenant Stroop came up with me. My two radio operators came up with me We picked up two or three of the bodies, dead or alive.

34:39
We picked up an armload of weapons, some ammunition, and came right and back and I came back to see Colonel Allen said sir alpha company's gone no alpha company up there And uh throughout the next couple hours, Colonel Allen would ask me, where's Alpha Company? So I told you, there's nobody up there. Now, Ted Stave Stroop, uh, eventually I came up there with my uh Ford Observer.

35:13
Dave Stroop made some other trips in there and brought back some living or dead guys uh brought back a lot of weapons and an awful lot of ammunition. We did not run out of ammunition that day. We had plenty of ammunition and we had plenty of weapons.

35:32
I was carrying M16 when it got shot. Just get another one. Now, Alpha Company's gone.

35:42
I'm in a tight circle. I expected a lot of alpha company people to come back to me, but just a very, very few did. I just didn't see off company anymore.

35:52
So that now I noticed that most of the fire came from that side, and then the fire from them just kept pick picking up. And pretty soon it was just a they were shooting at me because there wasn't anybody else to shoot at down here. The ones down there are already dead.

36:12
Tremendous fire. Then, as Colonel Triette told me, he told these guys to come up here. Which they did.

36:23
And just these these guys had already left. So they never, that would have been a terrible massacre. But they made it out.

36:30
Then these guys came up here and then they shot into us. Uh like that. And that fight went on from ten o'clock.

36:45
It got real heavy for us at 1015. And at some point my watch was blown off. At some point our artillery, which got started way, way late.

36:59
Our artillery stopped and the enemy came back in again. It never came around behind us. But that's kind of how it at twelve o'clock Colonel Triet left.

37:14
left. And when I asked Colonel Triet, why did you leave? Because all the Americans were dead and I was afraid the B-52s would come.

37:27
Gotcha.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)

37:30
Can you tell us a little bit more about the fact that they didn't fire off the mortar?

Clark Welch
37:38
There were there was a number of things that did not fire that day. start with to prove that they didn't fire. I can't do that.

37:50
I can't prove they didn't fire. I can just say they never fired anywhere near me. And and understand the enemy's right there.

37:58
So if we don't fire right there, it's not going to do me any good. But to uh start with the mortars and and Ray can end this. When the shooting started, up to the time the shooting started, I wasn't allowed to fire anything.

38:17
The first Indian Division SOP, standard operating procedure, said that only the lead company can fire, which makes sense. If I'd been firing also, maybe I would have fired up the lead company, so the lead company fires the trail company is just ready to do whatever they're supposed to do. I had planned for fire.

38:39
All of along everywhere, left and right, front, back. But I couldn't shoot it. But I was calling back to there are two kinds of indirect fire that I get.

38:47
I call back to the mortars. Calk directly to him and say, okay, if I were allowed to shoot, I would now want you to shoot Alpha 1. And he'd say, Roger.

39:01
And I guess they aimed the guns towards Alpha 1. And then when I got up here, I would say, if I were allowed to shoot, I'd now want to shoot Alpha 2. So it moves the guns a little bit.

39:12
And so that's right there, but nothing's being shot, but we're talking about now you'd shoot alpha one, now you'd shoot alpha two. come back then he can talk more about the mortars. The artillery's the same way.

39:26
We had artillery over here that we used on the 16th in Shantan, very, very well on the 16th. We had other artillery. I didn't care where it came from.

39:35

I just knew I wanted Pinky Durham to be able to get on the phone and get it. On the 16th, we had tremendous amount of artillery and mortars. They fired.

39:43
They fired because I called him directly. He draws on his board, sets the guns, shoots. The artillery fires because I yell at Pinky Durham and say there, there, there, and sure enough, within seconds, stuff comes crashing in on the ground.

39:59
On the 17th, I could not fire the artillery because I wasn't the lead company. I couldn't fire the mortars because I wasn't the lead company. Now when the shooting started and I when I ran down to see what Alpha Company was doing and nobody was there, then I ran back and got Pinky Durham and said, Pinky, come up here.

40:18
That way you can see where Alpha Company is. by this time the trees are getting knocked down. It's all getting pretty easy to see.

40:25
So you stay right here and you call artillery in, and then Pinky said they won't fire for me. And when I said Pinky will give me me the phone and I got on the phone and said you gotta fire. And the artillery, which didn't know anything about what we were doing, just said we we're only gonna fire for Alpha Company today.

40:44
They told me that. You're not Alpha Company. And I'm screaming The alpha company's gone, they're dead.

40:52
So there was about five or ten minutes with no artillery firing at all. because Alpha Company was telling me the mortars over there in Shantan, the artillery over in Shantan, was telling me we can't fire for you because oh we can only fire for Alpha Company. When I call back to these guys, they said we can't fire.

41:21
And after about ten minutes of me saying, You gotta fire, you gotta fire, and they saying, Well, we're not gonna fire, then he can tell you what the orders did. But the artillery, Pinky Durham called and got some other young captain back with the artillery. Pinky was able to convince him to fight.

41:43
And that captain back there with the artillery was able to say, okay, I'm going to fire for you. I'm going to get in trouble for this. I'm going to fire for you anyway.

41:51
And then the artillery was able to come in. And we had trouble down here because we didn't want it to land on top of Alpha Company. So we actually we couldn't see where it was down here.

42:02
We just knew it was B beyond where we thought Alpha Company was, it's beyond the bodies. But the artillery came into our left and right, pretty much exactly where Pinky put it. Now the mortars never did fire.

42:17
They fired on the 16th very, very effectively, but on the 17th the mortars three mortar platoons up there that would be what What nine, there's nine mortars, just eight hundred meters north of us. And that's eighty-one. Uh it's a big chunk of steel.

42:35
They never fired.

Ray Albin
42:37
Um On the 16th, just to go back, on the 16th, Clark and Delta Company was the lead company, so that meant that Clark had control over the mortar fire that day. And that's why we were able to fire, I think. And that's I think, you know, Clark said we did a good job, so, you know, okay.

42:55
On the seventeenth Delta Company was the trail company, so that means that that Alpha Company would have direct control over any mortar fire. But as Clark said, said Alpha Company was pretty much decimated within the first ten or fifteen minutes and therefore alpha mortars were out of the picture. And so at some point, and I don't know what time it was and and I was sitting next to a radio.

43:21
I wasn't on a radio. I was sitting next to a radio and I had a plotting board here and there was another guy with another plotting board. We always kept two plotting boards to cross-check each other.

43:30
And in in in anticipation of of the companies moving out that morning, we had all our preset locations w with Clark. And I imagine Alpha Company had the same. And I don't know what Bravo Company were doing because they were out of the loop in terms that They they their company was stationed inside the perimeter.

43:47
They didn't go on this S D. So in anticipation of the companies moving out, you know, we had

the rounds broken down. We didn't pull off charges on the rounds because we didn't know the distance, but we knew that the range would be very close, uh probably less than a thousand meters, if there's going to be any kind of Contact at all. It'd be less than a thousand meters.

44:08

And we also knew that we probably wouldn't be the first called to fire because Alpha Company was in the was in the lead. And then at the time when it did come to fire, and I don't remember Clark calling back. I I don't remember that.

44:21

Maybe I was doing something else. I remember prior to the the um the ambush being sprung that you can hear all the cross traffic on the radios and you know you tune a lot of that out because it's just chatter chatter chatter and then when the firing started then everybody's everybody's aware I mean we were already in the gunholes it's not like we were you know we were out cutting trees and then had to stop what we were doing and come back everybody's in the gunholes everybody ready. So when the firing did start, then we said, okay, probably Alpha's going to get the first shots or whatever.

44:53

So by the time it came for a Delta company to fire, we weren't firing. And I'm going to I'm just gonna step here for a second. And it would not have been um a a difficult uh a difficult line of fire because we weren't firing the the the uh Delta Mortars wouldn't have been firing over the tops of these guys, they'd have been firing to the flanks.

45:16

So we didn't have to worry about short rounds or rounds dropping on our own guys because it would be uh flanking fire, okay, which was For us it was ideal because you always, and there was a division policy, you don't want to fire over over the tops of your own guys. So in any event, it would have been a good situation. But I never knew why we didn't fire until maybe a few years ago, you know.

45:38

And then I I learned that we were prevented from firing. for whatever reason, by somebody higher up than me, and they wouldn't have been talking to me. They wouldn't have told me you can't fire.

45:49

It would have been through the chain like to Lieutenant Mager, the mortar platoon leader. He would have received the instruction from somebody you may not fire. So we're waiting and waiting and waiting and waiting.

46:00

And you can hear the fire in the distance. It's only, God, it's only 400 meters or 500 meters

away. And you can, and normally, given all that volume of fire, in the past, you know, firefights, you know, we've been right there.

46:12
We've we've fired. But this it didn't happen. And I don't remember Clark, you know, talking on the radio and asking for mortar fire because maybe I was separated at that point, walking around the gun.

46:25
gun hole or something, but I know that we didn't fire, and I don't believe there was ever a mortar round fired from that NDP. Now I can't speak for Bravo Company. I don't see Bravo Company being in the loop on this.

46:37
I don't think the Alpha Company ever fired because who was going to call for the fire? I mean they were all dead or people in command and controlled it. And then Delta Company would have been the only one that had the opportunity.

46:49
And I don't, again, I could be wrong, but I don't recall us ever, you know, firing around. And again, Clark says we We didn't, and so I'll accept that.

Andrew Woods
47:00
You were a sergeant in the mortar platoon of the case. Yeah, but on fire direction center. Your fire direction center.

Ray Albin
47:09
For fire, then there would be a set of coordinates or a pre-plotted point in this case. And then my job was to, that's why I sat next to the radio. I could hear that.

47:21
And so the radio telephone operator, the RTO, wouldn't have to relay the information to me. I could hear it firsthand, just like I could hear guys yelling into the handsets and screaming and doing whatever that um I could hear the coordinates or or whatever was happening. And then on my plotting board along with the other guy we would you know plot the points.

47:41
And it wasn't like we were having to make major corrections. Andrew, it was, I mean, these were minor corrections because we'd been following the the platoons, the patrol, the search and destroy, uh, the company all along. So these were minor corrections that can be could be done that fast.

47:57
And it wasn't like you're taking a whole set of coordinates and having to preplot and do all this extra work. So if they'd have been able, if if we'd have been able to fire, it would have been been very quickly, you know, because the rounds were broken down, pull a couple of charges and and hang some rounds and adjust, and that would have been it. But uh didn't happen Regrettably.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
48:25
Can you give us some insight into what was going on? in your mind throughout this battle.

Clark Welch
48:38
decided earlier that I wasn't going to get killed. I had an agreement with God or whatever it is. I wasn't going to get killed.

48:44
I was going to get hurt bad. Not not in this battle, just whenever I've been sent overseas to go somewhere. And I had Done that a couple times before.

48:52
I'd get hurt, but I wouldn't die. I'd I had a wife and two little boys. A lot of things to do.

48:57
I wouldn't get so when I got shot, it was really just kind of like god damn I knew that was gonna happen. I don't want to belittle it, it's not funny, but when I get shot in the leg, damn. And uh one of the riflemen that happened running by.

49:14
I uh banished my leg. It wasn't a bad shot, it just uh uh ripped in and out. It was just kind of okay.

49:20
I knew I was gonna get hurt, now I've got hurt. I got shot in the back, the chest, Army calls it. Uh damn.

49:29
Now I get bandaged up, but now I have to stay bent over all the time, so it looked kind of stupid. And then when I get shot in the arm, but it was still, I'm not gonna die. I'm not gonna die.

49:39
So with that all taken care of, that wasn't a thought. The thought was, what am I going to do with my Delta Company? That within, I've been in the Army ten years.

49:52

I knew that if you're in the army you can either shoot or move. Can do both, but it's not very effective. Unless you got ammo So as I'd done on the 16th, I was ready to, you know, bring a platoon up on the left, bring a platoon up on the right, do whatever the hell the battalion commit plan was.

50:14
But I could not move, partly because of the d fire that was coming in on top of us But mainly because my job was to follow and assist and take care of Alpha Company. And even though when I'd gone forward with Stroop and some of his guys, went with my radio operators a couple times. Uh even though there didn't seem to be anybody up there, I certainly wasn't in a position where I'd say, okay, let's get the hell out of here.

50:46
And then I also had the ten men in the battalion command group. The battalion commander, for Christ's sake. First time I'd seen him in the field like that.

50:56
The battalion commander, the battalion sergeant. Major, battalion operations sergeant, the battalion S2, three or four or five radio operators, uh Gilbert, the combat photographer. for Christ's sake.

51:10
But my job was to take care of them and the when I would come by the colonel, I didn't call him on the radio very much because the colonel was right there. I could just run up to him. and yell at him.

51:20
God damn, sir, what are we doing? Stay right here. Okay, good enough for me.

51:26
Battalion command, the battalion command group's gonna stay right here. My job is to protect them. I'm gonna stay here and protect them.

51:32
I didn't do a very good job protecting them. All of them got killed. Not surprising, they got killed.

51:37
They were throwing smoke. They had the big antennas with the ten-foot, they had the big radios with the ten-foot antennas up. But even after they were dead, you don't go off and leave ten dead guys.

51:50
So my thought was how how am I going to save my Delta? And uh I just kept running around.

Not running, if you stood up, he got shot.

52:03
Uh at walking around crawling around. How am I going to get them out of here? How am I going to get them out here?

52:11
And then finally at 1130 when it started to Back not so much shooting at about 1130. I think I did say things like, uh, you know, Stroop, get him out of here, get my Delta out of here. But most of it was just how how am I gonna save them?

52:34
How am I gonna not save them? But what what what can I do? Nobody's answering.

52:40
So after a while, I don't know how long I know I talked to Lieutenant Megar, who was the uh his platoon, the really wonderful man, just died a couple years ago. was killed a couple years ago. I know I talked to Lieutenant Megar.

52:54
I don't remember exactly our conversation, but he the it was screaming and yelling. I can't I can't shoot, I can't shoot. Well god damn it, shoot!

53:01
I can't shoot, I can't shoot. Well screw you. And uh I didn't need the radios to talk to my platoon, except to Meager, and Meager had already told me he couldn't shoot.

53:13
Well, I don't want to say I gave up on him. that the rate our radios were getting shot. Anytime I wanted to talk to my platoon leaders, I could yell, Stroop was right there.

53:25
Laberta was right there. My uh middle platoon leader had been evacuated that day. So middle platoon leader was run by a sergeant.

53:32
I just forgot his name, Dwayne Dwayne uh Bert. Dwayne uh Bert. Damn it.

53:38
I don't, geez. But a good wonderful guy. But I could talk to him.

53:43
You know, Stroop, do this, goddammit. Laberta. The middle guy that was right there at the battalion commander.

53:50

And anytime I wanted to talk, so that's what you do, you use your radio to talk to the platoon leaders, I could yell at them, grab them. Use your radio to talk to the battalion commander. Battalion commander's right there.

53:59
Didn't move an inch. From the when the first round cracked in and got Blackwell. Anytime I wanted to talk to Colonel Allen, I knew where to find him.

54:10
Any radios we hid, we sent up to uh Reddit. the uh where alpha joined uh Delta. That's where I brought uh Durham.

54:21
That's where he was killed. And whenever we had enough my radio, I told my radio operator to bring it up, and he stayed up there with Durham for a while. But then that radio would be knocked out, so we ended up with Yeah.

54:36
All of the good radios up there with him.

Ray Albin
54:38
And the word platoon, there was no question that like we were gonna be the cavalry and rush out to save them because There was maybe twenty or twenty-two of us or twenty-three of us, and that wasn't that that wasn't SOP. I mean that that would have never happened unless somebody's

Clark Welch
54:55
Under no circumstances would I have to do that.

Ray Albin
54:57
Unless Clark would have said, you know, mortar guys come out there, get your gear, and then you know, that's a whole different thing. Then you're what you're abandoning the mortars and you know there's not much sp I mean there's some specialization in in the army, but mortars was was specialization in the infantry and a guy couldn't just come into the mortar pit and and fire a mortar. I mean you could drop around.

55:18
But y you wouldn't know where it was going. So, and then more specialized was the FDC. There was only two guys that did that.

55:25
And so Well I don't know if we were smart, but there was if if there's two f FDC guys and both

of those guys leave and then the mortar gun crews leave, then you're rendering the whole mortar platoon useless. So we stood around just waiting and hoping and figuring the situation would change and somehow we'd start firing like we did on the 16th. And that never happened.

55:50
happened. It it you know like I said before, it never happened. So the our our our hope was that we would be able to fire because we knew that that would help.

55:59
But as far as going out there, that was gonna have to be a rifle platoon and the only rifle platoons available were from Bravo Company, and that was going to be somebody else's call. And then maybe another company, as it turned out, another company was hella lifted. in there and you know we're getting ahead of the game now but that's when there was actually some movement toward the ambush site later on after 12 or 12 o'clock or whenever that start that movement started.

Andrew Woods
56:28
Whose call would that be at the uh NDP? Jack Sloan. Okay. Yes. Major, right?

Clark Welch
56:37
Major Jack Sloan.

Andrew Woods
56:37
Excellent.

Clark Welch
56:41
There's two reasons he would have made that call. One reason is when the battalion commander leaves the night defensive position, which he was battalion commander. Commander was down there with us.

56:50
The ranking officer left back at the NDP, who had many more people. Say twice as many people. But there were twice as many people back at the NDP under Jack Sloan's command than there were forward under the Colonel's behind.

Ray Albin
57:06
And then when Charlie Company joined There was three times as many because that was another hundred guys as well.

Clark Welch

57:12
But that was the reinforcement by Charlie Company was later. He's the senior man in the NDP. Now the other reason that he would have taken it would have been meant his call, his battalion commander was no longer effective.

57:28
The battalion commander was Doing whatever I don't know what he was doing. I only when I came by to talk to him, he was calling for airstrikes. Didn't surprise me.

57:39
That's what he had done on the 16th. And I had said pretty strongly, and I'm told by other people who heard me, that on the 16th I said, if you bring in any airstrikes, I'll kill you. Because airstrikes happen a mile away.

57:53
And I needed couldn't even see much further than what you can see in this building. And when I when I talked to uh Colonel Triet two years ago, four years, five years ago. ago.

58:03
Colonel Triet said, we knew the only way we could survive was to grab you by the belt buckle. And he reached out and grabbed me by the belt buckle. That's the phrase.

58:14
used. So airstrikes coming in a mile away. He didn't even know about him.

58:20
I didn't know about them. I wanted the mortars.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
58:27
Now according to my readings, um it seemed that there was some there was some question or it it was unusual that Um, Lieutenant Colonel Allen was on the ground with the men that day. Can you tell me a little bit more about that? Was it indeed unusual? What were the feelings? about that?

Ray Albin
58:46
I can answer it real quick.

Clark Welch
58:51
You would think it was unusual because you'd never seen him out there.

Ray Albin
58:53

I've never seen him before

Clark Welch

58:57

Because there were a couple of times when we weren't in big fights, when we weren't in the long UN secret zone looking for the goddamn 271st. As a matter of fact, was right there. Uh when for the two weeks prior to that, Colonel Allen never moved with the battle. He stayed back at the NDP.

59:21

I don't think he was afraid. I don't think he's afraid. He just didn't command that way And on the 16th, he sent some element forward to command Delta Company and Bravo Company, who I never spoke to.

59:34

Well, I did what I caught talked directly with Bravo Company and told Bravo Company, don't let me Let them come in from our right flank. And so Bravo Company came up on my right flank. And nobody ever did come in there.

59:47

But uh the battalion commander normal Normally stayed back in the battalion as far as I know, always stayed back in the NDP. On the night of the 16th, when I heard them discussing what we're going to do tomorrow, General Coleman, Colonel Newman, Uh General Coleman, Colonel Newman, Major Hollander, Colonel Newman's S3, Colonel Allen. And I'm just a lieutenant, so I'm not discussing things, but they asked me what I was doing, and I heard what they were talking about I do not know if anybody ever saying, Colonel Allen, you must walk with the troops.

01:00:23

I was very surprised later on at the briefing when he said, and I'll be here with you. It's going to be a great day for the Black Lions. It surprised me that he would be with us when I'm a lieutenant.

01:00:36

He can go anywhere he wants. I thought, man, it's gonna be a pain in the ass for me to have to have ten big guys who aren't going to do me any good. They have rifles, but they're not going to shoot them.

01:00:49

I had never seen him out there with us before. I'd seen him overhead in a helicopter a lot.

Ray Albin

01:00:54

And I was there for seven more months, and I never ever, to my best of my knowledge, saw a

battalion commander or any battalion command group walk on on any kind of a patrol or company size or platoon size or reinforced squad size patrol. It just you know that I mean prior to that time I never saw it and subsequent to that time I never saw it. I'm not saying it didn't happen, but I just didn't see it.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:01:24
Would you like to take a break or would you like to keep going?

Ray Albin
01:01:27
I'm doing all right. I'm doing Okay.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:01:34
Do you believe that there was an important flaw in the battle plan, or do you think it was a culmination of of errors. Talk to me about that a little bit.

Clark Welch
01:01:46
It was a disaster. I think at one time, I know, the only time I was debriefed after the battle, it was a short debriefing in the hospital, and I've seen Captain Cash's interpretation of that. And I I wasn't very contributory towards that.

01:02:10
I just said that was screwed up. General DePew, after the after my tour in Vietnam, I came back and became an instructor and a senior instructor in And operations officer for the Florida Ranger Camp. A bunch of really tough guys.

01:02:26
I don't know how bright we were, but a bunch of really tough guys. I love that assignment. At one time, General DePew, who had grown up from being our division commander, he was now the head of uh trade or something.

01:02:42
He was the head of all forces and all training that required. remained in America. General DePew came down to the Florida Ranger Camp to talk about having a live fire and some other things down there.

01:02:53
And I I was in on that conversation at Brie. strongly. General Cavasso was there.

01:02:59
General Cavasso, who'd been a battalion commander during this battle, we were there. He was about down here. Not coordinated at all, but he was about here.

01:03:08
Insane. General Cavasso was there. Colonel Tucker, who was the camp commander, therefore my good friend, but during this battle he was the S3 for Colonel Cavasso.

01:03:21
became a four-star general. The pew is a four-star general. So five or six of us around the table and went through a debriefing and they said, what happened?

01:03:29
First and only time I was debriefed. I mean it's happening now, but 30 years went by with not a word spoken. But I did lay out, and at one time General DePew said, what did we do wrong.

01:03:43
And I made a list of 17 things apparently. I don't have that list anymore, but I had the list of 17 things. Now, it's a lot of things that are are deadly wrong.

01:03:55
Deadly wrong. Any one of them would have resulted in the Disaster. Now I have at that time the Army hadn't invented yet the word after action review.

01:04:10
At that time, after a battle, I always talked to as many people as I could. I either did that by going out on the perimeter, which took me a long time because God's all I would gather the guys together and talk to them. Or sometimes I hit them in the early morning, they would come in to get a cup of coffee, because my beautiful first sergeant would make a big pop.

01:04:38
No, I'd never reached out to the fourth platoon. But I would have a little after and what I'd ask them, I'd get the guys together and try to talk to them all. And generally you want to look at him, you know, make sure he's all right, because that's crazy business out there.

01:04:50
And smell the rifle, make sure they fired their rifle. Because I'd heard that people didn't. Our guys fired their rifles. But I would say, what'd you plan to do?

01:05:00
What happened? What would you do different? And then the next time, who here should get an award?

01:05:06
And then you find out that, uh, well goddamn, it's Private Jones, that halfway through the battle, Private Jones ran forward and got the only machine gun, brought it back, and started to shoot again. Jones Did you do that? Well, yes, sir.

01:05:18

So I'd write out a little note and send it forward saying Private Jones ought to get a bronze star. I don't know what happened to him. I think the assholes up there just threw them away.

01:05:26

But we had the little after-action reviews. Now later on, you know, and I was assigned for a while to different places where the after-action review became really important. And we have battlefield operating systems.

01:05:40

And they've divided what you do during battle into eight different groups. And you can go down through each one. And when you talk to the guys about, you know, what your plan was, you just tell them what your plan was.

01:05:50

What did you actually do? You talk about what you actually did. And then comes the battlefield operating systems.

01:05:57

And There's nine of them. And uh if I had that little piece of paper I could listen, we'd probably come up with the same things that were wrong. Let's just start to finish.

01:06:06

It was a bad plan. It was uh You know, uh it was it was bad intelligence. We had the intelligence.

01:06:15

I have the the first infantry division, int sum they call it, intelligence summary. for September 15th, October 15th. Now, that probably would have been produced on, we had very rudimentary print.

01:06:31

not computer, but those people those insums would come to you in a stack of paper that was uh the roll would be forty feet long. And it took a smart son of a bitch to go through there and say, well care about this. I don't care about these 25, I care about this, I care about this.

01:06:46

Now that I've got plenty of time, I've had a chance to go through it. We, the United States Army, knew where they were, knew where the regimental headquarters was, knew where the the battalions were, even knew about these reconnaissance, the reconnaissance companies, platoon, platoon, platoon, on these open areas because as he told me, he wanted to keep track of where the Americans' white men. Land the helicopters.

01:07:09

Now, I will have to admit, those intelligence summaries also said that the 271st is here, and the here, and the here, and the here. But what we hid, our intelligence Uh the first guy that stands

up to speak when they give a briefing is the intelligence officer. This case is Captain Blackwell, whose real job was to follow me around so he could take over the company when I became a captain.

Andrew Woods
01:07:35
But the Say say again I had trouble hearing you with the the paper.

Clark Welch
01:07:41
Oh okay Okay. And Captain Blackwell had a little staff of three or four people. And his job would be to later on when I was a battalion commander, brigade commander, you're the S2.

01:07:59
Oh sir, what do I do? You tell me where the enemy is, and you tell me what he's going to do. And the little guy would say, well sure, how do I know what he's going to do?

01:08:07
Well, god damn. You figure it out. You tell me where he is and what's he going to do.

01:08:11
I don't know if they ever told Captain Blackwell that. We were kind of too busy for that kind of stuff. We're in the MDP.

01:08:27
That's Captain Lom's house over there. The first thing you do in a briefing is a command and give the uh intel report And the intel is all the weather and the enemy terrain. Wet season remember.

01:08:44
The weather. Look outside. You see what the weather is.

01:08:45
It's gonna be wet and rainy, hot as hell. The terrain. There's no terrain.

01:08:50
It's just flat. It's flat green. It's triple canopy jungle.

01:08:55
Now the enemy. Where's the enemy? What's he going to do?

01:08:58
This is what that was. I got the wrong map up there because that doesn't can't show what I want to show. It was a smaller scale map.

01:09:09

Tom say Long time. This is the long new end's long to win secret zone. The first map that was put up there.

01:09:29
We're there. And we've been there. Used to be down here.

01:09:34
Red is the intelligence officer. Now I can tell you that when he briefed the weather, look outside the train, there is no train, just green, the enemy. This is what he briefed.

01:09:48
The 271st is in here, guys. He sat down. So the intelligence was screwed up as could be.

01:09:59
I'm thinking I've got a list over there of the seven battle operating systems. For each one of them I could tell you what we did wrong. Want me to take a couple minutes to do that.

01:10:07
Let me do that? Right and do that later.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:10:09
Yeah, that'd be that'd be good. We got the time. Um yeah, I think so.

Ray Albin
01:10:13
Maybe the This would be a good time while Clark's doing that.

Clark Welch
01:10:16
Yeah, you can ask him important stuff now.

Ray Albin
01:10:19
I don't know. After the battle, you know, obviously there weren't many um first second platoon two first second and third platoon guys remaining they're all killed or wounded evacuated but I never heard any of of the survivors then or at reunions now say, oh Clark Welch screwed up on that one. There was no blame. And I mean, and I'm telling you, in that division

Andrew Woods
01:10:49
you know, blame was commonplace at the higher levels.

Ray Albin
01:10:53
And and there was and at the at the platoon level and the squad level, you know, all my squad

leaders screwed up and we didn't get the ammo or the platoon leader screwed up on this and that And this was a major disaster, and nobody blamed Lieutenant Welch. Colonel Welsh, Lieutenant Welch then. And And nobody was around to to tell him, or he wasn't around for us to tell him that, you know, and and And this is not just the day after, which would have been the time when people would have been griping or looking to blame.

01:11:28
This was forevermore. And obviously again, you know, the mortar platoon wasn't there to assess blame because we weren't there. But we would talk with the guys and again you know even at reunions there's there's been no blame there but unfortunately Clark was evacuated and everybody went their separate ways the rest of Delta Company continued and we never got together until 2002 or 1 and Clark lives for all that time just talking to him knowing that you know, there's a possibility that he got blamed for for this because he's the company commander of Delta Company, the Trail Company.

01:12:13
And, you know, there's got to be something that that went wrong there. But It wasn't there wasn't any blame, you know, placed on on Lieutenant Welch.

Clark Welch
01:12:22
And I think that that un unfortunately I'm one of those old fashioned people that From the from when the time I first started school, I wanted to be a soldier. And I'd read somewhere, I want to be a commander. Whether it was a fire table, hell, I wanted to be a fire table.

01:12:35
Have two guys, you know, that's wonderful. There's a something I read that a commander is responsible for everything his unit does or fails to do. I still believe that.

01:12:48
I believe that I am responsible for my company. And uh blame, and I don't want to say that that I'm blamed for everything they do or not do, but I think I was responsible. Anyway, the uh these battlefield systems, I'll just they'll go down through them.

01:13:05
Intelligence. Zero. The intelligence we had was, you know, that's correct.

01:13:13
But it was available. It was not given to us. The second one is maneuver.

01:13:21
I'll put it on this same map. Our maneuver that day was to do this. Now, because we now know that they had dug in here, here, and there.

01:13:38
They'd been there for five days. They were occupying trenches that had been, he had an engineer company with him. Engineering company.

01:13:46
Their job is to dig in. No bridges to build there. So he'd been digging in for five days.

01:13:54
And our maneuver is to go straight south, the same way Bravo Company had done two days before. Insane. Insanity.

01:14:05
What that is is a direct attack, a frontal attack on a fortified position. Now if you look in the books, you're supposed to outnumber the enemy ten to one to do that. Just the little books.

01:14:17
The World War II books, they don't do that anymore because a well-trained unit can kick the ass of not a well-trained train you don't no matter what size they are. But generally ten to one if you're going to conduct a frontal attack on a fortified position. They don't numbered us ten to one

Ray Albin
01:14:34
Yeah, I was just going to say the reverse was true.

Clark Welch
01:14:36
That was our maneuver. Now within that, within the battalion, what was the plan for when we made contact? Delta Company going to come up on the right, Delta Company going to come up on the left.

01:14:46
Delta Company are gonna pull back, Delta Company are gonna move forward. Maneuvers are zero. This didn't have one.

01:14:52
Next one fire support. Fire support was a zero. Mortars never fired.

01:15:00
I don't think there was a plan for somehow, once the fight started, that all nine mortars back there would fire for us. I don't think there was any plan for that. Now the fire support from the artillery, they did not fire for Alpha Company.

01:15:16
If they did fire, it's too far away from me to hear. I've heard that they had marching rounds. I

don't know what marching rounds are.

01:15:23
I know what marking rounds are. If you're not sure where you are, you tell them to fire somewhere because the artillery can fire pretty accurately. So whenever I was lost I'd say a fire over there and boom.

01:15:33
Okay. Seems like it's about that direction, so I must be here. Nothing from them.

01:15:38
And then once Alpha Company would have fired, and that first couple's critical uh like on the 16th, within seconds of my seeing that guy, and there was probably uh af between the time I saw him and the time uh that I that I shot him and killed him and that started the attack on the 16th. Probably a minute in there. And that gave time for the artillery to shift and they'd been shooting for me all along anyway, so that I was just able to say, you know, the last place you shot.

01:16:11
uh rate hundred and twenty fire for effect. So within seconds we had artillery crashing in in front of us. And I'd had a continuous mortars behind us.

01:16:22
So Fire support Alpha Company didn't fire, or any that I was able to see. And then they wouldn't let us fire. And when we finally did fire, by that time it was almost too late because by that time they're right on top of us.

01:16:39
So okay and then the next step up in fire support is helicopters. Helicopter gunships. Never hit them.

01:16:46
Never hit. helicopter gunships. And then next step up from NASA Air Force TAC fighters.

01:16:55
I can't say never had them. I've read the stories where the uh guy claims that he was quite a wonderful person and he fired even talks about gun target lines, woof woof. Miles away.

01:17:06
Miles away. And even at the very end that the Commander, the division, whoever was in charge, I guess Colonel Newman, thought they were going that way. So sometime in the afternoon, the final thing, he brings in a hell of an airstrike down here.

01:17:22
They went that way. So air fire support zero. Next one is air defense.

01:17:29
We did very well on air defense. We did very well in air defense. Next one's mobility and survivability, taking care of the people.

01:17:38
We did pretty well in that. We had plenty of uh, they knew what was going on Uh mobility wasn't a problem. The guy up front had a machete.

01:17:48
In the in our case, he was pretty well beaten down path by the time. I the only problem I had was that since Alpha Company was in a single file, my first platoon could follow all right, but then my second platoon was in two, so they had to break their own path. And the third platoon was in two so they had to break their own path.

01:18:07
But we did all right on that. Next is combat service support. We have plenty of water.

01:18:13
We could have had more medical supplies, but that would have meant, you know. very quickly I ran. You're supposed to bring your own morphine but only give it to yourself.

01:18:20
Well hell I used up my morphine. Then when I got shot in the leg, I said, God damn, I wish I'd wish I'd I'd say about morphine. But we we didn't have enough medical equipment.

01:18:29
We had plenty of water. We had plenty of ammunition. We had plenty of weapons because we owed all the weapons There are plenty of weapons.

01:18:38
So we did our right combat service support. We should have had more people. As I've told my friends, uh because We've got many, uh Fred Kirkpatrick, who missed the battle because he'd been sent on R and R, another insanity.

01:18:53
How could the military take a com uh company that's in we fought every day From the eighth through the sixth, seventeenth. We fought every day. And I lost people every day.

01:19:06
Uh one goes back, one go one day one day uh ten went back, seven ten went back. sixteenth. Yeah.

01:19:14
And and No, they just go you and I talked about that. I just numbers went down. And then this thing comes along that I thought, you can't take my men away from me.

01:19:24
But an order came out from somewhere saying the following nine members of Delta Company are going to go on R<unk>R to Hawaii I told the first sergeant, Jesus Christ, this is insane. And then the first sergeant told me, the guys already know about it. You can't come out, you, Lieutenant Welch.

01:19:43
can't come out and say you guys can't go. So this business of comet service support includes having the right number of people there. We didn't have the right number of people.

Ray Albin
01:19:51
Seventy five in a rifle company.

Clark Welch
01:19:52
Should have had a hundred and eighty five.

Ray Albin
01:19:54
And sixty in alpha

Clark Welch
01:19:55
Yeah, it's crazy. But they we didn't have enough people. Now as I've told my my friends, Fred Kirkpatrick, who resents every day that he was not, he's a squad leader.

01:20:07
He was absent. Fred Kirkpatrick doesn't forgive himself for not being there. And my only words to him and the other guys who weren't there was, Hell, if you had been there and brought a thousand of your friends, it wouldn't make any difference.

01:20:22
Because he's in trenches. He's got a thousand four hundred. We only had a hundred and So combat service support we didn't have near the people we should have had.

01:20:34
And final one is command and control. None. No orders.

01:20:40
Issued. The night before, this is what you'll do. While the battle goes on, I did not hear, I was within the town committee right there.

01:20:52
Sometimes I was one foot from him because you couldn't couldn't hear anything, so you had to

get real close to talk. Uh I never heard him give any orders. And that's what after after something has happened when when you ask people, you know, tell me about it, you tell them, you tell me what your actions and orders were.

01:21:09
What were your actions and orders? Don't tell me what you were thinking about. Don't tell me what you you would have done, you know, you, Sergeant Alban, tell me what your actions and orders are.

01:21:19
That's all it counts. What were the actions and orders of the division? commander using the side gun.

01:21:25
Brigade commander, I don't think he even knew we belonged to his brigade. He didn't show up until the battle was over. Battle started at 8, it was over at 12.

01:21:32
Battle started at 10, it was over at 12. Battle commander Took no action. Action meaning you know you shoot somebody.

01:21:41
Gave no orders. You know, go left, go right. So command and control just uh zero.

01:21:52
That's how the army would look at it now. Those are the battlefield operating systems. And uh we did not do very well that day.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:22:04
Getting back to Ray when you were talking about um blame. Was was there any blame um placed on the higher ups?

Ray Albin
01:22:15
You know, I probably sh I don't know, blame is so There's always blame, there's complaining. And complaining is is is commonplace. Right. Complaining Is is commonplace in the Army at the First Division Museum. Any workplace, there's always complaining.

Andrew Woods
01:22:39
And blame put it this way, there wasn't

Ray Albin
01:22:45

Isn't any blame placed on the company commander? I don't think people, I don't even know if guys that survived, whether they were in the mortar platoon or in the the rifle platoon. platoons.

01:22:57

I don't even know if they knew that Lieutenant Colonel Allen was out there. I mean the guys that were out there with them did, possibly. So I I don't know if if I never heard any blame for for anything above you know the the the the company level.

01:23:15

I mean nobody ever I don't remember everybody ever saying Uh Lieutenant Colonel Allen sure blew that one or something. I don't even think they knew it just doesn't filter down that way. You know, I mean Clark would have known and Captain George would have known that Maybe Alan was or Alan was calling the shots, but we didn't. And so I don't remember any blame being assessed.

01:23:36

I remember an effort to find out what went wrong. Clark's successor, the very next day that we got back to life took each of us individually into the mess hall in Lyke and one at a time asked us what we saw, when we saw it, where we saw it, what we did, and what our impressions were. And that was, I understand, from him just talking to him six months ago.

01:24:00

This was Captain Grosso and Captain G-R-O-S-S-O. And he did that upon himself. But he wasn't doing that to assess blame. And he kept that report, I understand, to himself.

01:24:12

It was just he wanted to get a feel for what the company had experienced. And he was somewhere that day monitoring a radio and acting as an intermediary between Between you know, whoever it was is in charge. But that to answer your question, I don't remember anybody looking to blame anybody, you know.

Clark Welch

01:24:33

Because of my belief that uh commander is responsible for everything his unit does or fails to do, I blamed Colonel Allen for many years. I didn't tell anybody. I mean there's no I did say to people, you know, nobody gave any orders, but I never used the word Colonel Allen.

01:24:52

Uh but I did believe Blame them for what happened. Blame. Until the fifth hundredth anniversary of the regiment, which we got together at Fort where we get together at Fort Jackson.

01:25:05

recall that and uh General Shelton was writing a book David Moranis was writing a book And

they arranged for me to meet the three daughters of the colonel at the reunion, thinking that that would be Uh General Shelton used it, even the words that uh that'll be a good hook for my book. I guess that's a word that book writers use. It'd be good hook.

01:25:33

We'll have you he didn't tell me. I didn't know what's going to happen. And uh halfway through the meeting, we were in the big ballroom.

01:25:41

And uh I didn't know that was going to happen. General Shelton came up behind me and said, Don't you get it, don't try to run away, don't you move. And Shelton.

01:25:49

Generally I say yes, sir. What the what what do you mean? You stay right here.

01:25:54

Don't run away. I'm not gonna run away. And he was standing with his arms on shoulder on on arms on my shoulders.

01:26:01

And then at the far end of the ballroom the door opened and uh David Mariness came in with two of his daughters. Two of uh General Allen's daughters. I had not known that Colonel Allen was famous.

01:26:15

I didn't know what his first name was. I didn't know his father had been the commander of the first Army Division. To me, he's just Colonel Allen a bit battalion commander.

01:26:21

Yes, sir. No, sir. I didn't know he had three children.

01:26:27

I I thought I remember seeing a picture of uh he and two a picture of two little girls with him on the last day. But uh I didn't know that he had children. Certainly did know that he had trouble with his marriage unknown to me.

01:26:44

But I blame for what happened that day. When David Moranis came with the two women towards it, and one of them was wearing a white dress, looked like Marilyn Monroe. The others wearing a red Chinese dress.

01:26:55

Beautiful girls. And as soon as I saw them coming in and realized that Shelton's holding on them. me and here comes this David Ranis looks like a famous Pulitzer Prize whatever he looks like a famous Washington Post editor with these two girls and they came towards me.

01:27:10
And they're about ten or twenty feet from me and the two girls girls broke away from me and came running up towards me and the uh girl in white, I forget her name by uh I shouldn't remember her name. One in red scons will Caroline White came up and said to me, You know who we are? And I said, yes, you're my colonel's children.

01:27:37
You are the children of my carnal. And I've I physically felt just uh uh whatever it is and far beyond my understand you what but when I was hugging those two girls uh the blame absolutely went away I do believe he's responsible But the blame went away. And I didn't want to let them go.

01:28:00
They didn't want to let me go. They had already read some articles about how I'd said. You know, the colonel's at blame.

01:28:08
The colonel's responsible. Everything, I haven't blamed them. Blamed him.

01:28:15
Actually died when I went back. later on to the place where he died and his uh Consuelo, his daughter, was there with me. Two of us are standing there and I said, it's right around here, Consuelo, is where he She started crying and said, Daddy, Daddy.

01:28:33
So I don't blame the colonel. Now, one of my soldiers, and I won't tell you his name, but one of my soldiers soldiers. Told me a couple of years ago.

01:28:43
See, you know, I hate officers. He was drafted, he'd only stayed in for a couple of years, got out. But generally you're talking about the bigger.

01:28:49
Very understandable very understandable. He said I hate officers. I said, damn.

01:28:54
He gave his name. I'm an officer. He said, no, no, no, sir.

01:28:57
Not you. I hate officers. He said, I wish Colonel Allenridge had survived so I could kill So there's at least one man who blames Colonel Allen.

01:29:13
I do blame the system for allowing somebody who was under the pressure that Colonel Allen was under to come back and take command of a battalion in a big fight. I blame the battalion

brigade commander for leaving the bodies out there. Blame the division commander for not knowing what the hell was going on.

01:29:33
And accepting a silver star for it after it was over.

Ray Albin
01:29:39
That's not to say that when I was talking earlier that we didn't question what happened. Because, and not to be egotistical, but Damn it, this was the Black Lions. I mean, this was a highly successful organization before I got there, and uh they were v we were very good at what we did.

Clark Welch
01:30:01
Couldn't be happy. When it started, and I'd already told them they see six is going to be sixty. I believe that.

01:30:10
If you see six, it's sixty there. That's just the way they are. And later on when the terrible fire just started and kept getting worse and worse, I thought, Jesus Christ, this is more than 60.

01:30:22
More than 10. This can't be. And then uh when they stopped firing, or when it really quieted down about 1130, and then I'm not sure what happened after that.

01:30:37
I certainly didn't think, man, we have smacked into the 271st Regiment that the division has been chasing after for four years. Even then I didn't believe that. When I got at the hospital and then when I got to the hospital in Japan were no contact with anybody even though some of my men were in the same hospital but they didn't tell me.

01:30:59
It never I never read in the paper that the Black Lions fought the 271st, 1400 of them. Colonel Triette and Captain Blam, when I was standing on the battlefield talking about them. They said all 1,400 of us fired in the Americans that day.

01:31:16
I couldn't, and that's in line with what we're the Black Lions. We're goddamn good. We're Delta Company.

01:31:24
We're about as good as you can get. But man, we really got whack. Must be a couple hundred of them out there.

Ray Albin
01:31:32
So we we did question I'm sorry, were you finished? So we did question, you know, how could that have happened? And then in light of what happened on the sixteenth, when pretty successful operation on the sixteenth.

01:31:46
It was really good. Yes, and and then in light of all that that that most infantry companies have going for them in Vietnam, the helicopter gunship support, uh And prior to the the engagement, you know, we have artillery, we have mortar fire, we have a number of things in our favor. So if any company does get in any kind of trouble you have a number of resources that you can call upon to to make the plane feel level or assert uh a a greater fire superiority or whatever.

01:32:19
So it was this was unthinkable that that that that happened. And not just because we were the black lines, but also but because we had all this support and you always had that support. And airstrikes, you know, that's always the the given that the that the the pavant could never even uh counter because they had no air force, you know where we were.

01:32:39
So all that. So there was the questioning that went on the days after. And then guys were trying to find out answers.

01:32:44
and you read the Stars and Stripes and you read Time magazine and all these things are are that's where I learned about reporting that it isn't always accurate. It it's to sell newspapers and magazines. magazines, I think, not the stars and stripes, it was free.

01:32:57
But it this wasn't accurate. And then only years later, you know, did it did the truth, what I guess is the truth, or at least more questions were answered. with the books and being able to discuss things and and this sort of thing too.

01:33:12
This is why this is so valuable.

Andrew Woods
01:33:14
I gotta show you the the uh American Traveler, the Division newspaper.

Ray Albin
01:33:18
Andrew, I I have that. And I sent that. We did pretty good that to I sent that to Clark after you sent it. I said, I'm not sure if you'd seen this or not, but here goes and and it's It's you know, the

best that they could do at the time or some you know caveat, you know.

Andrew Woods
01:33:37
Let's see, you answered uh uh most of my questions here, but I I still had a a couple Newman takes over after sometime after noon at the NDP from uh Major Sloan, the operations officer. Officer. Do you have any idea why why would the first brigade commander take over from the battalion's S three?

Clark Welch
01:34:05
I don't know. I I do know that uh when we went to the field, we didn't belong to Colonel. We belong to Third Brigade Commander.

01:34:19
And looking at things now, you know, the uh it's just the Third Brigade log, which I have a copy of now. It's just all of a sudden the second of the 28th appears. You know, the first couple weeks of First Brigade Log, there's just no 28th.

01:34:36
Then here's the second or twenty eighth. Now normally, usually, when when you're a brigade commander and you take control of an additional battalion, it's a big goddamn thing. You put in there, you know, at 1226 today at X-ray Tango 183625, I became the commander of an additional battalion, the 2nd 28th, Lieutenant Colonel Terry Allen.

01:34:58
Commanding. Nothing in there. Just a little note that all I mean as you go down through the days, all of a sudden the 2nd 28th is listed there.

01:35:07
I believe it was kind of a strange relationship. The battle started at 10 o'clock. The 3rd Brigade command 1st Brigade Commander was located just a little bit south of Con Chantan.

01:35:25
Chontan. Maybe five miles away. How long does it take to fly five miles in a helicopter?

01:35:32
That was the only action that we had that day Five miles a helicopter in maybe three minutes. Battle started at 10 o'clock. He gets there sometime after 12.

01:35:43
What the hell is going on? And when

Andrew Woods
01:35:49

First first he puts uh Sloan in in command and then a few minutes later.

Clark Welch
01:35:58
He owns the NDP. And he owns a battalion because he hasn't been able to talk to the battalion commander for some period of time. So Sloan is already in command.

01:36:09
Now, now I I am not sure what the answer to your question is. Why would somebody take command? We already had a perfectly good commander standing there who'd been there for a week.

01:36:27
Who'd been there for the battle? A mile away. He never came towards us.

01:36:32
Good question.

Andrew Woods
01:36:34
And do you know why the battalion executive officer, Major Gillard, was in Lycay that day?

Clark Welch
01:36:41
Yes, the battalion executive officer should have been in Like. The same well I won't say the same way. I'd extrane my company, my second in command is my first sergeant, which is kind of against the books.

01:36:53
Your second in command is supposed to be the XO. But I had my exo back at Ly K. His responsibility was to make sure we had food, everything, ammunition, water. He did an excellent job.

01:37:05
Got ice cream through four Four times a week, didn't we?

Ray Albin
01:37:07
Not a week, but we did get ice cream every once in a while.

Clark Welch
01:37:11
Yeah, for that matter. Yeah, so was CXO of AC. Yeah, and he should have been, Tom Grady.

01:37:17
The battalion XO should have been back in Like. Because it we were sending people back to

him hurt all the time. He should have been rounding up replacements to send forward.

01:37:25
I only got one replacement on the evening of the 16th. Other than that, it was just constantly whittling down. They went away.

01:37:32
They were shot Nobody's killed until 17th. So the battalion XO Gillard being in Lyque was perfectly normal and should have been. Now Should he have flown out and taken command?

01:37:47
I don't know. That's a you know command call somewhere. But he stayed in Lyke.

01:37:52
That's normal.

Andrew Woods
01:37:53
Yeah, according to the uh Air Force report that I sent to you Newman had already taken command of the NDP by the time the XO gets back.

Clark Welch
01:38:08
I I don't know. I I I would guess by w what I've heard, but I don't know.

Andrew Woods
01:38:16
Uh you've read uh Gener General Shelton's book, The Beast Resign. out there. And uh one of the big questions in that is whether this is an ambush in the terms defined. in uh Shelton's book or is this a meeting engagement or or what how would you characterize it?

Clark Welch
01:38:36
That's one of the slides I may use tonight because it uh now what is it? I know what it is. It's a search and destroy mission.

01:38:45
That's one of the missions. Now, it's a search and destroy. Our job is uh the mission to Sandandoa is search and destroy the two cities 71st. Well, we we we did pretty good in the search part.

01:38:56
We should have found them. But it was a search and destroy. We didn't do it very well.

01:39:02
Did the search part real good. But it was a search and destroy. Was there an ambush?

01:39:08
Yes. An ambush is an attack, unexpected attack, on a halted or temporary halted enemy. Well, it was an unexpected attack.

01:39:19
We should have expected it, but we didn't. And we were halted or temporarily halted. It was an ambush. It was also a meeting engagement.

01:39:31
Meeting engagement is a contact between one of the forces is unexpected. unprepared for it. We're unprepared for it.

01:39:41
We should have had 2,000. Well, usually you want to be about three to one if you're attacking. So we should have had 3,000 people.

01:39:47
We only had 142 So it was unexpected. That is a meeting engagement. It was all three of those.

01:39:56
It was all three of those. Now there are some other things that it could have been. It was a hasty attack.

01:40:05
We didn't move very much, but you know, when when you come into fire from the enemy, enemy you conduct a hasty attack. I attacked by fire. So it was a hasty attack.

01:40:15
It was also a movement to contact, sort of. I'm not saying these are the primary things. It was a hasty attack, not a very good hasty attack.

01:40:24
There's only four or five of us shooting, but it was a hasty attack by fire. It was a deliberate attack. We knew the enemy was there, knew they'd been there for two weeks, knew the day they crossed the river.

01:40:37
So it was a deliberate attack. We just didn't do it very well. Uh what else was it?

01:40:44
There's one other thing it was.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:40:46
There's a s it's listed.

Clark Welch
01:40:48
It was a uh movement of contact, deliberate attack, hasty attack.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:40:53
Surprise. I have I have uh ambush.

Clark Welch
01:40:56
It was it uh for sure it was an ambush. It was an ambush. It was a meeting engagement.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:41:05
Deliberate attack.

Clark Welch
01:41:06
And it was a search and destroy. There is no doubt it was, and I will argue with I don't want to argue with anybody anymore, but that's what it was. And uh that's what it was. I don't care what other people say.

Andrew Woods
01:41:22
Now in that uh Air Force uh report they said that the 271st Viet Cong were known for making what they call double play ambushes. Yeah. Yeah. That that they'd attack the lead force and then they'd also attack the follow-up forces.

Clark Welch
01:41:45
I don't know what the two seventy first does. In this case the two seventy was dug in there, there, and there, because they were sick and tired and didn't have any food. They didn't set up an ambush.

01:41:55
And as Colonel Triet told me, he said, Colonel Triet told me, that I prayed to my God that you would turn aside. And and then in fact when he told me that Kyle Horst, who was the interpreter hired by David Moranis. Came running over in there and said, what what what?

01:42:15
And I said to Kyle, okay, it's none of your business. And Kyle asked Colonel Triet, what did you say? And and Colonel Triet said, Yeah, blah blah blah blah, which I thought I understood.

01:42:27
And then Kyle said to me, he says that he uh plagued to his God that you would turn aside. Now

that that's not much of an ambush. When the I mean, that's n that's not him setting up any two-pronged bullshit first to last.

01:42:42
Uh that is him uh conducting an unexpected attack on a Temporary or halted enemy, so it is an ambush. But he didn't set up an ambush.

Andrew Woods
01:43:01
Over a hundred lost.

Clark Welch
01:43:06
I did ask him and you asked me on the phone, uh how many casual you know, I said uh I I lost a lot. I lost hundred and forty two people. He said, I'm sorry.

01:43:15
I said, how many did you lose? And the this was in the meeting room back at the uh big government place the day before we went out there to together. He was on his side of the table and I was on my side.

01:43:28
And when I said, how many did you lose? the handlers behind him, about six. The chief of the Office of Public Affairs, all the communist handlers and interpreters.

01:43:40
Said, no numbers, no numbers, no numbers. There's a word for number, I remember what it is. But Kong Kong no uh whatever it is.

01:43:47
No numbers, no numbers, no numbers. And Colonel Tripp. And okay, no numbers.

01:43:54
And then the next day we're out in the field. I said, how many did you lose? said a company about a company.

01:44:03
And then he said again, you know, if if you were wounded, you died. And if he left them behind, he never did pick them up again. So he left behind 60 to 100 people.

01:44:18
fair exchange. But he did he hid 60 to 100 casualties. And that's because he told me I lost a company.

01:44:30

And he told me he lost a platoon earlier out here on the 16th. He lost a platoon and he lost a company here. And as we talked about casualties, and I said Or something.

01:44:46
And he said, well, you know, we didn't lose many to artillery and air, which is your strength. Because we grab you by the belt buckle so close to you. And then he said uh that's it that's twice.

01:45:03
He said it once to uh consoy And I was standing with Gunzoiler. And he said it once to me, we were together in the van. He said, on that day, no one won.

01:45:13
And then the other thing he said, I was going to tell you. He said, don't feel bad about that. You saved my life.

01:45:20
What do you mean I saved your life? Shit, I would have killed you if I'd seen you. I tried to kill you.

01:45:25
Never killed you. saw you. He said, no, you saved my life.

01:45:28
He said, my job was to go from here when he was over here on the other side of Highway 13. in War Zone D. My job was to go through the long wait he didn't call them long wind zone. He didn't even call it North Southeast.

01:45:43
Vietnam, it's Vietnam. My job was to go from here across here to the vicinity of Nui Ba Den, a big mountain bare rock just sticking up. The center of New Eva Den and then turn over and come back up this way to uh locked in.

01:46:00
Where do you have that big battle with?

Ray Albin
01:46:02
Lock Nin.

Clark Welch
01:46:02
Yeah. To get up to Loch Nin to join up with the 9th Infantry Division. And I was scheduled to be, as always, the lead regiment.

01:46:13
And but when I showed up over here and linked up with the 9th division, I was late and I'd lost so many people. So he didn't let me be the lead. Regiment.

01:46:24
And as you know, the Americans, the second of the twenty-eighth, wiped out the lead regiment at locked in. And and that's what Colonel Colonel Trent said you saved my life. Okay, sir.

01:46:38
I I I love Colonel Triet. I mean uh he's uh I want to say my friend, that's not the right I don't think he lied to me anyway.

Andrew Woods
01:46:56
Is it a a professional Professional kinship?

Clark Welch
01:47:00
A professional? I've told people before I never feared them. I never feared them.

01:47:09
But I respected them and I admired them. I didn't let anybody I didn't let anybody in my company call them gooks. I mean that was a common phrase for them, was gooks.

01:47:19
And uh I'm sure my men talked about the gooks, but not when I was around. I I don't believe I ever used the word gook. They were VC, Vietnamese communists BC.

01:47:37
I respected them. I admired them for being so tough. Bitches didn't uh didn't have anything.

01:47:45
Uh And I admire, respect Colonel Triet, Captain Long. And my men do, not all my men. Four or five years ago at Reno.

01:47:59
Uh a lot of my, not my, but men who'd been in recon. Recon is special. Sough, crazy kids.

01:48:07
Uh when I was recon platoon leader, that you're supposed to have 30 men Usually about 20 because a bunch of them in the hospital because they get shot. They get beat up and they're in fights all the time. But the uh we had about 20 recon guys at breakfast around a table in Reno.

01:48:22
And uh this was between my two visits to Vietnam. And I wasn't sure how how I should tell him that I've met Colonel Triet, but I wanted So I said, guys, you know I was in Vietnam. Yeah, we

knew you were.

01:48:35
How'd you like it over there? Seeing any little girls? Oh yeah, fine girls.

01:48:40
Wisps. Wisps in ow yes. And you see any women, you know, can can you still get a massage for 25 cents and all that kind of crap.

01:48:54
And then uh I said, you know, I met Colonel Triet, the commander of the 271st. And one or two of them jumped up and said, did you kill him? No, I didn't kill him. He's my friend.

01:49:06
You should have killed him. And we had a conversation about that. They were very serious that I should have killed him.

01:49:13
And so maybe you should have killed me. You know, the so I I I I love these recon guys. They're they're They probably won't be here tonight.

01:49:20
I don't think they attend lectures and stuff.

Andrew Woods
01:49:24
Actually, uh Jake the Snake.

Clark Welch
01:49:27
And I believe he was at that table at Reno, I I think. I think he was there. And a guy down at the end, this tough son bitch has two names.

01:49:38
He uses one name in civilian life, one name it is undercoverable life or something. something. Oh yeah.

01:49:43
You you know about him. I don't know if it's true.

Andrew Woods
01:49:45
I've heard your stories.

Clark Welch
01:49:46

Well he was sitting at the far end of the table and he gets up and he takes a hat and he says I just want a lot of money at uh relic wheel. I'm going to give $100 here. So when Colonel Welch goes, or Lieutenant Welch, I call me, when Lieutenant Welch goes back to Vietnam ever again, not sure if he's going to, I want him to give this money to Captain L. That tough little sunbitch that lived right there, and you're right, Lieutenant Welch.

01:50:10
We should have burned his house down. Because his, he was on the recon, went back and forth. on the other side of the river to screen our activity.

01:50:17
Well as I said to these guys sitting around the table, yeah I met Captain Lum. God damn you guys should have killed him twenty years ago. Your jobs go to you know here's a map.

01:50:27
The 125 5,000 map that I wish I had shows his house on there. That's the house that's still there, the house I slept in one night. Well, Recon should have found him and killed him.

01:50:36
Well, I had a great time. And uh I don't want to say his name. Maybe not allowed to say his name because he works with a company or something.

01:50:43
But uh I'm not sure who it is. He said, here's $100. And he put it in the hat.

01:50:48
And by the time the hat got down to me, there's $1,000 in it. And I was able to, I put some more money with it. And I was able to give some of that to Colonel Triet and Captain Lom and another company commander like Captain Lom that was down the road that I didn't know about, but I went to meet him.

01:51:07
I respected them. I admired them. I am sorry that so many men get killed.

01:51:15
sides. I never hated them. Never hate I hated our leaders that were screwing up so bad.

01:51:23
I hate incompetence by anybody. Still do. I don't do anything about it anymore.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
01:51:34
I wanted to ask you how How do you feel about some of the major works created? Um how how do you feel about some of the major works, whether books or DVDs or articles, whatever, the major works Created about the battle.

Clark Welch

01:51:48

I read them all, starting with McGarigal's book, ten or twenty years ago, Steel Ring. And I didn't recognize it. Then, I mean I didn't re what the hell is this?

01:52:04

It's not what I remember. uh steel ring. Then I uh read Shelton's book and uh personally I felt kind of bad.

01:52:16

Man, I didn't mean to do all that. I thought it was kind of a good guy and here's Shelton's right there's Shelton Shelton's uh fine son bitch. He says he says what he thinks.

01:52:26

Not like a you know general that's supposed to give you some kind of clasp Where you learn not to don't say these kind of things. You know, say everybody's wonderful. And uh Shelton's was right on the mark as far as he went, but that's all he knew.

01:52:41

Shelter's is very good. Then there's three or four others in there that uh written by some guys that we know and love, and if they were here I'd buy 'em a drink and everything. But it's uh uh a good old some private who gets hell, privates get I was a private private.

01:52:55

You get crapped on all the time. Life is not good for a private. And and two of these guys have written books.

01:53:02

And those books are uh uh based on the truth. Uh they talk about me sometimes in there, how stupid that I am and how made him do this and made him do that. Well you goddamn right I did.

01:53:13

So there's a couple of those books that are neat. I've got them, I read them, they're neat. Moranus's book is a life saver There are some of my men, you'd know the name, I don't want to give his name, who tried to commit suicide by shooting himself in the head of a 45.

01:53:29

That's not like taking sleeping pills. That's a. Pretty goddamn serious. And he survived.

01:53:35

And he says he'll never do that again. Because now the book is out. Uh says he'll never do that again.

01:53:42

All of I can't speak for all my soldiers. He he didn't have to have written the book. Just doing his

research, calling me up and saying, like all All of my men did.

01:53:54
You know, you get a call from, I'm the secretary to a Pulitzer Prize winner. We're gonna fly you all expense paid to Washington, D. C. Most of my guys said, screw you. I don't want to talk about it.

01:54:05
Where were you 40 years ago for Christ's sake? You you worked for the Washington Post. What'd you do 40 years ago, you bastard?

01:54:11
Which I'd still say if he was here. I do say. He didn't have a very good answer.

01:54:17
He was doing other things. Anyway. So my guys more or less didn't and then Shelton called many of us and said, you can trust men.

01:54:28
It's all right to trust him. And then all of this is to come up with that book is a wonderful piece of work. And he saved lives.

01:54:38
makes it different for me that the uh many of us have marched in the sunlight because of the research for his book. The idea that he would call me and I'd say, I'm I don't want to talk to you. Don't let any you found me.

01:54:51
Don't tell anybody where I live. Why? Because the guys have every right to burn my house down, shoot me.

01:55:00
Said, no, I've talked to these two, and then eventually I've talked to these 50 guys. It's almost all the survivors. None of them want to shoot you.

01:55:10
And he was able to say to them, Because they would say, you know, we love Colonel Welch, Lieutenant Welch, but we're embarrassed because we passed out too. Or didn't fight as hard as they wanted to. It makes me cry when I realized that those guys for 30 years.

01:55:29
Gilliam, a man who's a very successful engineer building battleships, Newport News. Gilliam wa was one of the specific men that cried when he told me. I would say he cried, but sure I didn't want to I knew where you were, but I didn't want to talk to you because uh You would find, you know, remember and then he told the story.

01:55:48
I said, Jesus Christ kill him. And the story was he was the original radio operator for Pinky Durham that day. Because the sergeant had been shot and killed a couple days before.

01:55:59
So Gilliam was and I grabbed Pinky, said, God damn it, come up front with me so we can see what's going on. on and of course bring a radio operator gilliam and gilliam stayed there and I ran up and I said what the hell's wrong with you get off you bring that god damn radio up here and Gilliam's just laying there. So I came back and said something, you know, give me the goddamn radio.

01:56:24
And snatched it off him and ran forward. And Gilliam spent 30 years thinking, you know, Colonel Welch is mad at me. What turned out I know now Gilliam had been shot in the leg so he can't move.

01:56:38
That's why he didn't come forward. And the idea that uh I would raise hell with anybody, you know, if uh I wish uh I wish all my soldiers were here. But the idea that when he did his research, he was able to tell those soldiers.

01:56:53
When they'd say, you know, don't tell them, don't tell the major that don't tell the lieutenant where we are, because I passed out too soon. Jesus Christ, you didn't pass out too soon. How come you passed out?

01:57:04
Well, I've been shot eight times in the arm. Uh so the research he did for that book did most of it. And then when the book came out, half of it Which I've read the other half I've looked at.

01:57:19
Now the TV show is very, very powerful. But it's awful and I'm sorry I participated in it. A PBS show?

01:57:32
Uh the TV uh three days in October.

Ray Albin
01:57:35
Two days in October, yeah.

Clark Welch
01:57:36
We did we didn't know that it was being funded by the University of Wisconsin. We didn't know that one of the writers, you know, how can you have a writer for a documentary? You prepare

questions to make me say certain things That's what he did to my guys.

01:57:55
So we got Sikorsky's sister saying, we don't know whether it's right or wrong. Bullshit. Uh what?

01:58:05
It's uh uh so that movie's the T V the uh D V the the T V show. Uh uh none of the uh the picture it's stock footage of uh the guy that picks up the body and looks at it and us. The guy's marching along elbow to elbow on the Dyke, then in us.

01:58:26
If if maybe maybe I'm screwed up, but I don't believe I would have let Delta Company do that.

Ray Albin
01:58:32
They wouldn't have done it.

Clark Welch
01:58:33
And when I when I called Bob Kenner and said that's a goddamn thing, I'm sorry I participate. It's a piece of shit. Uh Kenner said uh you know the uh we have to use stock footage.

01:58:46
Once you get some stock footage footage of my guys. So that that's not a and later on that that got a couple of high awards, Emmys or Peters or whatever the hell it is. And both times he invited me, I said, no, I'm not going to go.

01:59:00
Well that that was not good. Makes me a little bit nervous about what the movie is going to be if there is a movie. I will not recommend to my guys that they help.

01:59:13
I did recommend to my guys that they helped because a lot of fellows called up and said, we just You know, two years before, we got a call from David Moranis and he wants some information. And should we talk to him? Sure.

01:59:25
David Moranis is going to put out a big uh With Kenner's thing there. I thought we could trust him. And so I told my guys when they'd call and say we and he he flew us out to Hollywood, spend overnight in a boat.

01:59:41
Boutique hotel. I'd never been in a boutique hotel in my life. Interviewed both my wife and I. Interviewed you on the phone or whatever.

01:59:49
But that piece of work was not good, which means that if somebody calls me and said, you know, do you want to uh play General Hay in my movie? Screw you in your movie. Trying to think of what else did they come out with.

02:00:04
I won't say anything, but they what else has have they come out with? I think those are some of the major you wrote a beautiful piece. Uh you, Carrie, that uh because you were not there, weren't even born yet, don't have an agenda, uh It was a beautiful piece of work just because of that.

02:00:31
But the other thing that you were able to divide, maybe that's not what you meant to do, but you were able to divide it into those four or five phases, which are exactly right. And the idea that you added on that final phase that after thirty years of I think I called you I think I told you the darkness and silence of thir thirty years. But that's not the end of it.

02:00:53
I was afraid it was going to be the end of it. I was afraid I was going to go to my grave thinking about that with no no goodness to it. But then you talked about the last five years, that in the last five years his book, Shelton's book, his book and Shelton's book.

02:01:13
It made such a difference. You are angels.

Ray Albin
02:01:20
Yeah. Um I read Brigadier General Shelton's book and uh it was fine. I mean it is it it was interesting to read. I didn't always agree with some of the conclusions. You know, and he got into a large-scale discussion of five years.

Clark Welch
02:01:39
But in the last five years, his book, Shelton's book, his book and Shelton's book. have made such a difference. You are angels. Yeah.

Ray Albin
02:01:54
Um I read Brigadier General Shelton book and uh it was fine. I mean it is it was it it was interesting to read. I didn't always agree with some of the conclusions You know, th and he got into a large scale discussion of whether it's an ambush or this or that and He disagrees with me on what it is, but that's all right.

02:02:17

And and that's who? General Shelton? Yeah.

02:02:19
Yes. And that's okay. You know, it was interesting.

02:02:21
And then when David David Moranis's book came out, that was very good. And I read the whole thing. I read even the I suffered through the part about the protesters.

02:02:34
And I read that and I I read all the time anyway, so this was it was good. And it was good I I think for everybody that participated. Because they had a chance to talk about it.

02:02:49
For me personally, it was bad, not in the sense of bad writing, but there was a certain element there that I was telling Clark last night at uh after dinner or sometime, that for for many years I put this whole thing I just didn't think about it. But on October the seventeenth I would be in the classroom, I'd turn my calendar to the seventh And I'd pause a moment and think, or maybe once or twice a year, I'd think about it. But when David's book came out in 2003 in October Now there hasn't been a day gone by that I haven't thought about it at least once.

02:03:23
You know, and whether that's a good or bad thing, I don't know. Oh no, no, I I haven't no I'm not ready to do that yet. And and Clark on conversely tells me that, you know, he's thought about it ever since.

02:03:35
I mean, since October 18th, 1967, all the way to the present. So I I don't know how the other guys were. And I I mean it was good writing.

02:03:45
David Moranes is a great writer and he's a nice guy. And that was a great book. And then came um Robbie Kenner's uh two days in October.

02:03:58
And I talked to him on the phone for an hour or whatever. And then that one when I watched it, it was captivating because this is, you know, I'm a history, I'm a history teacher and there's history, and I was a part of that even though I you know wasn't on the film and you know didn't use my picture or anything and that's fine. But there was too much spent on the periphery People on the periphery.

02:04:27
I I can't understand to this day why a guy, Pinky Durham, who won the Congressional Medal of Honor, is not mentioned in that film. And Colonel Allen's wife, who might be a nice person, had

a tremendous amount of film time. And she was the wife.

02:04:48
of the guy who led us in the battle, so to speak. That did not belong there.

Clark Welch
02:04:53
And I should say for the record, and again it Pinky Durham should have had a bigger part in in Maranist. book. Agreed.

02:05:01
But he's dead. Agreed. You know, and Pinky Durham should have had a bigger part in two days in October.

Ray Albin
02:05:06
And I don't think he's even mentioned No, no, he he if if they would have said Pinky Durham, that would have doubled the amount of time he had in the in two days in October. I mean he wasn't even mentioned there. And so with in that regard and and in fairness to Robbie Kenner, he won a tremendous number He won awards for that and acclaim.

02:05:25
And he's produced a great number of other things for PBS that on war in Guadalcanal. And he told me uh John Brown's body and I think those are are well done. You know, this one, however, uh, you know, I talked to Rob, he asked me what I thought of it, and I told him I thought it was good, and I didn't add the part about um Durham.

02:05:44
Then I watched it again and I watched it again and I realized that that should have occurred and there should have been less time spent on the what I call the soap opera aspect. And that's my opinion, and I'm not in Hollywood, and Robbie is, but And and I don't know I and then lastly yours which is going to be published and and as I recall the the segments of yours were were right on. You'd taken the time to talk, you cared.

02:06:14
and that'll be well published. Or it'll be published and it'll be done well, I'm sure, when you're ready. Yes.

02:06:20
And then I also have great fear of This being made into a film. First of all, you're going to condense it to two hours and twelve and a half minutes or something, being facetious, but they're going to have to condense it. They're going to try to sell the film.

02:06:35

And that means that some things are going to change in the interest of historical, you know, accuracy. It's not going to be there. You know, because they the Hollywood tends to do that.

02:06:45
And if a documentary Can do it two days in October that a film for your entertainment is gonna do it. So I really am concerned about that. And I think that if they ask Clark, I gotta tell you, Clark, I think you should so you can get it help them get it right.

02:07:01
I'm trying to I don't mean acting. I don't mean acting in it. I mean somebody there to make sure that they're gonna at least we have some input to do it right because you you can then say if they don't do it right, well I was there and I told them this and they didn't do it, you know.

Clark Welch
02:07:15
So you would be like the spokesperson or or I did that for David Moratus. uh I was able to do that. That was that turned out good. I didn't work for David. I went on my own dime and everything because I could leave if I had to.

Andrew Woods
02:07:31
But are you talking about the C-SPAN uh Yeah the C SPAN and the C SPAN was there.

Clark Welch
02:07:35
The C SPAN Lady made a show called The Writing of a Famous Book by a Famous Author. But but the main thing I did over there was get get to talk to David and to make sure 'Cause the the uh Vietnam is communist. They knew what we were doing, they knew our names, they knew that I was a colonel used be a lieutenant.

02:08:01
And they attempted to do some other things. You know, would you like to meet the command of the Fouloi battalion? No. Doesn't have anything to do with this.

02:08:11
Well, he's right here, you know, he's very famous.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:08:19
I only have Two questions left. Um, and I think you've you've answered most of one of them, but if you want to add anything, feel free. Um, you know, the popularity of the internet has helped provide and to start and these other sources that we've talked about, they've helped to provide and start therapy really for many of the survivors who haven't really talked about it. Um, you know, and reunions have helped as well. I just want to know is there anything that you want

to add about, you know, how those things have helped the healing process?

Ray Albin
02:08:53
internet for me was the the the the link that allowed me to be in contact with guys that I hadn't even and Clark is you know two it sent Since 1967, because the Vietnam War was a strange war. You went over very few guys went over together and came home together. You went individually, except for Sea Packet.

02:09:15
Well those guys didn't go home because they were killed. But you went over as an individual, you came back basically as an islander, an individual too. So for I mean, I never saw anybody that I was in Vietnam with.

02:09:28
until two thousand and three or two thousand four. And and and that was because the internet started and then um my platoon leader, the guy who's now deceived Joe Devine contacted me and said, these guys are on the internet and these guys are here. And now there's not a day that goes by that I'm not in contact.

02:09:49
And I'm not saying it's always meaningful contact. Sometimes it's a lot of- It's easy to delete. Yeah, yeah.

02:09:55
There's a lot of stuff that just traffic, you know. But the whole point is, like I wrote to those I I you know, one of my philosophical moments years ago. When I first started on this, I said, you know, this these emails are you know quickly deleted, but we should keep doing this as long as our fingers can It doesn't happen as much as it used to, but once in a while guys will digress and send you something or or ask you something.

02:10:28
And it's it it brings everybody together so much so that That Jerry Grasso asked six of us from the Delta Company that he took over after Clark left to come to his place in Puerto Vallarta. This is six mortar guys That went down there and just had a great time. And that would have never happened, you know.

02:10:48
And we weren't always talking about Vietnam and this and that. I mean, you know, that d but we talked about it enough. And th that's going on.

02:10:55
And it's not just with with Delta Company, second twenty-eighth. I imagine it's happening with the first CAV and the and and the twenty-fifth and Infantry division and hundred and first and

and name them. You know, it's happening with all those guys.

02:11:09
So it's it's been a a great thing and the guys that care not to participate because they they want to stay the way they work. they you know we get the message and you don't you know but it's it's it's been a good thing the internet you know for for us you know and for a lot of guys a lot of guys came out of their sh shells. And a lot of guys feel more accepted and gives them a chance to talk.

02:11:30
And even though you're talking, you know, with keyboard instead of verbal And then guys that I didn't I never went to a reunion. Then after the internet I I started attending a few and and some I'll miss, but there's some that I go to. And I think it came that opportunity.

02:11:47
So it's been a good thing.

Clark Welch
02:11:49
You know, you uh I I'd agree with all of that. You asked if there could be something else. The uh we have the reunions.

02:11:57
Uh we had a reunion here. at at first university museum or this area, whatever this is, this is Chicago, but you were here. It is very helpful, or was very helpful to many of us to come out here and look around at what you have in this museum because what it brought to us is you know that October 17th was a horrid day, a disaster.

02:12:23
Just hard to find anything good. And we left. The next day we left.

02:12:28
Never went back. But if when you come here, you got this group of guys and you come in here, you see that there's been October 17th all the way back to the Revolutionary Wars. Indian War.

02:12:43
That yes, it was screwed up that day. And yes, I was responsible for that that day. But man, it's happened a thousand times before.

02:12:54
And I guess sadly it'll happen again and again. It's happening today. And it would it was very useful to us.

02:13:02
Reunions are good. You drink, I don't drink myself, but I I mean I act like I've been drinking while

I'm there. You drink, you have a nice meal, uh we're we're over Las Vegas, we'll go out and gamble, I guess, next uh later on this month.

02:13:14
Uh but when we came here, we did all of that stuff in Chicago. wasn't downtown Chicago, wouldn't it?

Ray Albin
02:13:19
Right. It was the Palmer House. Yeah.

Clark Welch
02:13:21
But then we came out and spent some time out here that was the highlight of the thing that uh and and it was the point that uh it was a bad day. But hell there have been bad days all along. Somehow that's reassuring.

02:13:36
Now that's that's crazy, but somehow that's reassuring. Yeah, yeah, we had a bad day. day.

02:13:42
It happens all the time in our line of work.

Ray Albin
02:13:44
And for for me, I mean I this is the first time I've been to the museum. I didn't hook up with the guys that went out here because my phone was dead in the room in the Palmer House. But this the first time I've been here and I I mean I've always felt like you know I could I've read that the black lions were part of the lore and the history of the first division, but then you walk through the exhibits and you see you know the pictures and you just look at the place and you feel even more I don't know if this is the right word attached I mean to a museum you know can you be attached to but it it was it's it's really been a spectacle and that's part of it too and I wish I would have come here or been able to come here with the guys from Delta Company when we were here in we're in Chicago in oh five or something.

02:14:30
Oh yeah. Well I my phone was dead in my room. They said they'd call me and the thing was unplugged or whatever.

02:14:34
So anyway, I mean th this is a good thing too. And then you can see the the tradition going back to you know continue to to Operation Torch in North Africa. You can see that Operation Shenandoah has its place.

02:14:48

So you can see that it's just amazing. And I think that's a good that's a good feeling. You know, even though the the topic that we're talking about, as competitive as I am, I hated to be a loser.

02:15:01
you know and be a part of a losing um thing but that's the nature of war and then i i i mean i have to tell you that a couple of weeks later the black line Lions did a good job of killing bad guys. And that makes me feel to this very day good. And you know, my wife will not like me to say that, but she's not gonna see this.

02:15:24
unless I decide to play it and maybe my kids won't like it either, but they kick some ass in and make me feel goddamn good, you know. And because that's my thing. I mean that was the way that that that the black lions got back.

02:15:37
And then the rest of the time I was there, we never took many casualties at all, certainly nothing to this extent. And we always dealt out more than we could more than we took. And to me as competitive as I am, I don't look competitive, but I'm very, and that made me feel good.

Carrie Gabaree (Tarasuk)
02:15:59
For the last question, I want to move back to the battle for just a just a moment. And we understand if you would like to turn the camera off for this question. But We wanted to ask you about how you feel about the decision to have the rest of the bodies um, you know, on the battlefield till the next morning.

Ray Albin
02:16:20
Well you know what? I mean it's uh as far as I'm concerned they could leave it on because to I mean this is Clark's call too, and if he wants to turn it off it's fine with me. But as far as I'm concerned, uh you could leave it on because I As a history teacher, this is for perpetuity and I think it needs to be said. Okay, that's my opinion, but I'm gonna defer to Clark. That's your call, Clark, because you know more of the big picture than I do.

Clark Welch
02:16:45
I I can easily say I wasn't there.

Ray Albin
02:16:48
Oh.

Clark Welch
02:16:49

I'm not gonna I'm not gonna say that. Come on man. You gotta help me out.

02:16:53
You can easily say I wasn't there. So I mean I wasn't there. So this is a uh a statement of a professional army officer who is a soldier for 31 years and then worked another 12 years working with soldiers.

02:17:09
It's a incredibly bad decision. When I went back to Vietnam, Captain Lom on the battlefield, stand right there. He came up to me one time and uh as we were talking about said in Vietnamese and he puts his finger there's real short guys he's a bad soldier ain't I'm a bad soldier that you left uh bodies out on the He left the bodies right here.

02:17:41
It wasn't until five days later that you got the last one, it was right over there. And uh uh that just devastated me. Yeah.

02:17:52
I'm not a bad soldier. But yeah, the people Captain Lom is the only American soldier he's ever seen the last 10, 20, 40 years. years.

02:18:02
So uh I felt just I can uh Yeah we shouldn't have done that. Now the other parts of that, we had a full moon that night. I know that.

02:18:16
I'm I'm very aware, not now, but I'm very aware of those kind of things then. We had a full moon. Now cloudy, of course.

02:18:23
It's cloudy and muggy over there. We had the power and might of the United States Army. We could have run that son of a bitch with napalm so that nobody could have got in and out.

02:18:34
We could have put napalm up and down. We could have got the bodies back. They put 25 bodies in a stack.

02:18:40
That's what they say And then they fired artillery around them all night. Well, artillery, uh, if you're not right there watching it to say, oops, that was a little bit long, twenty meters right. 20 meters left, 20 meters right.

02:18:56
Nobody was out there doing that. So those, if you go to the Vietnam Wall. .

02:19:03
And you see the cause of death, most of them are multiple fragmentation wounds. I didn't see any multiple fragmentation wounds. The guys I saw killed were killed by bullets because there's somebody there shooting bullets at them.

02:19:25
Well I think uh it was uh I don't want to say stupid, that's kind of an emotional word. Bad decision. Now, that battle was over at 12.

02:19:37
12. That's when the 271st left The only people left then were were caretakers, the guys, and as Captain Lom said, his job is then to run out there and police up the battlefield. One of his jobs, find wounded guys and bring them over to the hospital and find dead guys and bring them over to the he didn't call them mortuary, he said the dead guys.

02:20:00
So Captain Lom comes running out, and also his best source of fresh water was right at the head of that draw, at the head of the draw. draw. So he he got out and got fresh water for his family.

02:20:12
His family wasn't living there, but the people that lived in his house. And his job was to pick up bodies. And all those American bodies were there.

02:20:20
And uh uh Carl Horst jumped in there and said uh something in Vietnamese. I said, What'd you ask him? 'Cause it uh I resent having a hired interpreter jump in there and try to say anything other than when I say a sentence I want him to say the sentence.

02:20:33
I don't want him to wait until I said a whole paragraph. So he jumped in there and said, what'd you say? And I I asked him if he'd uh if he'd uh disfigured the bodies in any way.

02:20:45
And I said, well, that's a hell of a question. I looked right at Captain Lom and said, do you do anything on those bodies? And Captain Lom said, no. And I believed that.

02:20:54
I believe Captain Lamb. Now I am sure that when the 271st, that's the 1200 people, I think sooner or later, and and they were mixed right in with us, that one of them My guys came to me and said he captured one. What the hell are you talking about?

02:21:09
They captured one right over there. What am I supposed to do with him? Shit.

02:21:14
And I said. I said, let him go. He stood up and ran a couple feet and got shot by the enemy that was boring into us.

02:21:24
But we were we were all mixed in together. And I'm sure that somebody from the two As he ran through us, probably kicked somebody in the head, maybe cut an ear off. What they did.

02:21:35
Sorry. I'm sorry they do. I'm sorry.

Ray Albin
02:21:38
Well the books, I mean I don't I yeah I can't speak because I wasn't there, but I read one of the more disturbing parts in the book other than the question that we're about to answer or answering. Is it they were in among the wounded executing some of the wounded, Clark. And I don't think it's a very good thing. I have heard that.

Clark Welch
02:21:55
Yeah, well that's why I say I'm sure there's some people that came through and did that. I'm I'm sure that at least one of my soldiers were shot and killed by the enemy. Sixty-four were shot and killed by the enemy.

Andrew Woods
02:22:07
But you mean as a wounded?

Clark Welch
02:22:10
As the wounded, yeah. I think that happened. But I believe uh Uh Colonel Triet says he didn't do it because he'd killed you all.

02:22:17
That's what he said. We'd killed all the Americans. So we left.

02:22:21
Captain Lom had a job to do. Now, at 12 o'clock, the battle ended. There was no more enemy.

02:22:30
I mean the enemy left. Captain Lau went back to Taking care of his rice and his sick, and his job is to pick up the wounded. And Colonel Triad left.

02:22:44
Now I just forgot that I know. I know exactly when the sun went down that night. Between 12

o'clock and whenever the sun went down, 1800, 1900?

02:22:55
Whatever it was. That's plenty of time. They could pick up the wounded and carry him back.

02:22:59
You don't have to carry him back. You only have to carry him about uh two hundred yards and get them to the draw. We could have landed a CHP 47.

02:23:06
It takes 60 people. It takes 80 dead ones. They were spending an incredible decision.

02:23:13
They were spending their time just looking back at it. Incredibly Wrong. Wrong.

Ray Albin
02:23:19
Because I recall they were sp 'cause I was there then. At that point, we had gotten out there. And they were spending their time, the guys that had the chainsaws, because because it was triple canopy, trying to cut places for helicopters to land as opposed to taking them however many meters it was. to the draw. So but they were having great difficulty with cutting enough space because they could only land the Huey's and they can only take maybe five or six out at a time.

Clark Welch
02:23:49
It could have gone that way.

Ray Albin
02:23:50
Yeah.

Clark Welch
02:23:51
And that's uh two hundred yards of the draw. And they could have put a CH forty

Ray Albin
02:23:57
And a CH-47 is capable of carry- it could have probably carried all the guys out, right?

Clark Welch
02:24:03
No, they took out some of the dead ones. They took out the ten dead from the command group.

Ray Albin

02:24:07

And they took out others too. But the point was, is that is that in reading David Ranis' book, and from what I know, is that it was very difficult to get the choppers into where the evacuation area was. And I think one of the recommendations that I I saw somewhere was that more and better chainsaws need to be to be available post operation or post-battle or at the time or whatever, you know, for you know whatever reason.

02:24:37

Okay? So, you know, that occurred. And that's a mitigating factor.

02:24:43

But then Clark points out that it's very difficult. It takes two men to carry a dead guy. I mean, unless you want to carry him on your back.

02:24:51

So We're carrying guys on stretchers, and it's difficult, but who cares? You carry them however far it takes and get clear the battlefield. And that didn't happen.

02:25:02

Fortunately, I didn't know about them not clearing the battlefield of our dead. until David Moran's book came out. And I must have read that paragraph, section, chapter, whatever paragraph.

02:25:20

I guess I've read those multiple times because I I simply could not believe that. I didn't know that. But everything else, David Moranis, and I know that the links he went to write factual statements.

02:25:30

So I had to accept that. as the truth. Now I know how many guys, roughly how many guys were carried out, but then his book says that there were 35, 30, 25, 35 remaining.

02:25:44

And nobody gets left behind. I mean, Mike Goodale will tell you in Blackhawk Down, they spent a tremendous amount of money of time trying to evacuate all their killed in 1991 in Mogadishu there. And this is 24 years earlier and the same rule you know occurs.

02:26:04

And And I remember my son and and I think my wife looking at the Blackhawk down, why are they spending so much time and risking so many guys' lives to get dead guys out of there when they can just go get 'em back the next day? I said that's That's not the point. The point is that if you're going into combat and you know you're going to get killed or you know you're going to get wounded, it's really reassuring to know you're not going to get left out there.

02:26:28
And that makes you, you know, all the more uh the more close to the guys that you're with. That everybody's in this together and we're gonna get out of this or, you know, one way or the other, and we're gonna use either you know come home on our two feet or somebody's gonna be carrying you, you know. And so for us to leave guys behind, me was un unconscionable.

02:26:49
But I didn't know about that. But that day, if they would have said, okay, look guys, you guys that are all here, that you know there's there must have been There was twice as many at least. And Clark probably has the the more accurate figures.

02:27:09
But if they would have said to us, okay, look at we can't get enough choppers in here, the sun's going down, we got 25 guys. That we're not going to be able to evacuate. What do the officers, what do you guys want to do?

02:27:22
I'm sure there would have been many guys stand up and say, well, we'll just we'll just spend the night here. and and let 'em come and whatever, you know. And whether that's foolish or I don't know.

02:27:31
But I know, I mean, it's easy to say I'm sitting here in a chair, you know, outside of Chicago, but I know what I would have done, you know. And I'm and I know there's guys there that would have done the same thing. That you, you know, court on all I don't know if you could have dug in positions or whatever, but something was have been done.

02:27:48
And as far as and like Clark said, if you're going to adjust artillery on 25 stacked bodies, who's out there adjusting the artillery saying drop 5-0? or left five zero or whatever. Nobody was out there.

02:28:00
So it was the best guess. And I guess it did work because the next day they went out there, policed not police, they picked up the bodies and and recovered them and they were intact. I think there was two WIA, two MIAs.

Clark Welch
02:28:13
Two still missing.

Ray Albin
02:28:15
Yeah. But but the point is, is that it it they were left there overnight, and I don't think that they

had to be in a they did have to be, there could have been somebody that stuck with them. And nobody would have been there holding their hands, but there would have been this cordon of guys around there.

02:28:29
And of course, like I said in the we did this in St. Louis. You know, I gotta believe that somebody said that that was probably a bad call because they knew that the the North Vietnamese were coming back or the Pavan were coming back and they were gonna outnumber us and you know we'd all been wiped out there or whatever. But uh uh I'm just saying is that I think that that that had to be done.

02:28:49
You know, but I didn't know for all those years that those guys were left there.

Clark Welch
02:28:54
But as soon as I found that question of were they all dead.

Ray Albin
02:28:58
And some of them apparently they said rigor mortis hadn't set in on two or three they found the next morning. So therefore, and I think I've told you this before therefore those guys must have been alive for a certain amount of time and I I told that to now unconsciousable yeah yeah I I told that to Joe Devine, my platoon leader, in Chicago. We went to breakfast and I said, Joe, I read that book, and they said that Rigor Mortis hadn't set in on some of those guys.

02:29:23
He said, get over it You know, you can't go back, you know, but still that bothers me too as much as anything. And I I just think that if guys said known, knowing the type of guys that were in the black lions, knowing the type and any unit. I mean cavalry, you know, like 101st Air, knowing guys, they would have said, we'll stick around here and see what happens.

02:29:48
You know, give us some more ammunition or whatever.

Andrew Woods
02:29:53
But that that brings up a another question. I I heard that the we need to break. Well yeah. Unless you want to have an X-rated I can come back.

Clark Welch
02:30:06
Where do I go?

Andrew Woods

02:30:07

Oh